She-Ra in the Portal

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39018216.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Gen, F/F, F/M, Multi

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Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, One-Sided Scorptra, Background Relationships, eventual glimmadora, Angst, Light Swearing, season 4, but Adora is in the portal instead of Angella, Hurt/Comfort, glimmer is a badass, Portals, other characters appear but they're not the focus, Glimmadora - Freeform, Glimmer Swears (She-Ra), Catra is a jerk, let Glimmer say fuck, Catra is So Done (She-Ra), Catra doesn't want relationships, but Double Trouble likes Catra, light shiptease, Long Live Feedback Comment Project

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English

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Part 1 of Portals

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by ThatADORAbleWarriorLady

Summary

Queen Angella allows Adora to stay in the portal. Now the Rebellion must continue without She-Ra. Glimmer is determined to bring back Adora, but that might require Entrapta's help, even though the Princess of Dryl had worked for the Horde prior to the portal going off.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

I came up with this story idea while re-watching "The Portal." I've always wondered how the show would have went if Adora took the sword instead.

Not all canon scenes from Season 4 will show up in this story, although there may be some mention or description of what has happened.

This story is part of the LLF Comment Project, which was created to improve communication between readers and authors. This author invites and appreciates feedback, including:

Feedback

- Short comments
- Long comments
- Questions
- Constructive criticism
- "<3" as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction

The author may not respond due to real life taking up time, but will appreciate comments.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Angella, I'll take the sword."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes..."

Several rocks whizzed past Adora, and she jumped onto one of them. The rock levitated her toward the sword. She could hear

Angella shouting her name, but she was focused on one goal: to sacrifice herself. So, she grabbed the hilt and pulled it away.

Adora wandered past the vacant structures. She had no destination in mind. Time worked differently in this reality. How long was she here? The memory of sacrificing herself was still fresh, as if it had happened yesterday. How was the Princess Alliance doing without her? Did they keep fighting the Horde together, or were they about to split up? The wind howled past her as she left the deserted village. Her ponytail swayed in the breeze. She made her way into the Whispering Woods. Twigs snapped under her boots as she navigated the forest.

Suddenly, the surroundings shifted from the forest to the center of the Crimson Waste. Adora stared at Mara's ship. She wouldn't forget the way things went after Catra, Scorpia, and their allies stormed the ship. Was the magicat living with *her* choice? She gazed at the darkened sky. Countless stars blinked into existence. Was she the only person in this false world? It would be nice if she could talk to someone. She thought of Glimmer and Bow. They had always been there for the hero ever since she joined the Rebellion.

The pink-haired princess had a tendency to be touchy-feely with Adora. Their time in the steam grotto was one such example. Not that Adora minded. She didn't learn about romance during her time as a Horde soldier, as it was considered a distraction. She had seen Spinnerella and Netossa touch each other in an affectionate way. There were moments when Glimmer held her hands, gazed into her eyes, danced with her, and gave her a comforting caress. Did it mean that the princess saw the warrior as more than just a friend? Her heart fluttered as she dwelled on those thoughts. Despite the possibility of being stuck in this world forever, she held out a flicker of hope that she would see her friends again.

"Hello there," a female voice said.

Adora whirled around. Standing before her was a brunette. *Mara?* Maybe she was imagining things because of how lonely she felt. Mara wore a kind smile. She had seen her at the beacon when things were disappearing from existence. Despite Mara's youthful appearance, the woman's gray eyes seemed ancient. To be fair, the former She-Ra was alive a thousand years ago.

"Last time I saw you, you were a hologram inside your ship," Adora said. "I wanted to find answers regarding my origins. Right now, I'm stuck here as a result of taking the Sword of Protection to stop the portal. As the current She-Ra, I was supposed to save Etheria, not fail in my duty."

"You saved Etheria before it was erased from existence," Mara replied.

Adora sighed as she crossed her arms. "I know. I wish that Entrapta was wrong about me being trapped after taking the sword."

"Earlier, I saw two people with you. Are they your friends?"

Adora nodded. She didn't have the chance to say farewell to them. "They were my best friends. When I defended Thaymor from the Horde, they accepted me. We've been on a lot of adventures together... until Catra took me hostage and set off the portal."

"Sounds like you miss them." There was sadness in Mara's voice as she spoke. "I had to leave behind a few friends, too."

Adora listened to Mara's every word. They had something in common; both women sacrificed themselves to save Etheria. Now the two She-Ras were here, discussing their choices. They began strolling, unsure of where they might go. She scrutinized the expanse, searching for signs that someone else existed in a world separate from their own. So far, however, she didn't see anyone other than Mara. Were they doomed to navigate an abandoned

Etheria together? When fatigue began slowing them down, they decided to set up camp.

Adora entered the tent and slipped into her sleeping bag. Her eyelids grew heavy, and a yawn escaped her lips.

A week had passed since the Princess Alliance lost Adora to the portal. After returning to Bright Moon Castle, Glimmer had hung She-Ra's sword on the wall in Adora's bedroom. The Queen could have saved the warrior. Yet Angella allowed Adora to stay behind. Adora had always been self-sacrificing. She-Ra would rush into battle to protect others, risking her life to put everyone first. Despite Adora being a formidable warrior, Glimmer wanted to protect her friend.

Glimmer stood in front of her mirror, staring at her reflection. Her eyes were bloodshot from crying last night. No amount of concealer could hide the dark circles. Everything was different without Adora. And without She-Ra, the Princess Alliance would be at a huge disadvantage. As of recent, the Horde hadn't made a single move. Were they busy celebrating after Adora stayed behind in the portal?

Glimmer brushed her hair to one side. It was now an asymmetric style bob. The door creaked open. She expected her mother to come in. Instead, it was Bow who opened the door. She hadn't been talking to the queen and the archer as much as she used to. Also, she had refused to join meetings with the Princess Alliance. What was there to discuss? Those meetings would remind her of her loss. She wanted Adora back.

"You've been quiet lately," Bow said as he walked to the cushion and sat.

"We lost She-Ra," Glimmer replied. "She was going to lead the Rebellion to victory." Tears raced down her cheeks. "How can we continue without her?"

"We can continue fighting the Horde. Adora wouldn't want us to give up."

"But can we stand against the full might of the Horde and their armies?" Glimmer strode to the window, observing the land surrounding the castle. "We need She-Ra to help us in battle. It's not the only reason I miss her, though."

Memories of Adora surfaced in Glimmer's mind. The sheer delight in those steel-blue eyes as the blonde tried sweets and petted a horse for the first time. The way Adora smiled. That dorky grin had always warmed Glimmer's heart. Their friendship might have been platonic, but she had always harbored feelings for the warrior. She never got to tell her how she felt. The portal and a certain magicat had taken Adora away before she could ever have a chance to do so.

"I'll go talk to Light Hope," Glimmer said. "Maybe she can create a stable portal and retrieve Adora."

The lab was a mess. Shattered tanks dripped with liquid. Broken pieces of the machinery were scattered across the metal floor. Catra stepped onto a familiar pair of cuffs. They once held Adora's wrists. Even if her former friend was gone, that name still infuriated her. It had angered her when she found out that Shadow Weaver left her for Adora. When the sorceress had brought the Princess Alliance into the Fright Zone, it had been the last straw. A part of her wished she was still in the fake reality, where Shadow Weaver was kind to her. Originally, she had wanted Adora to rejoin the Horde. It was the reason she attempted, but failed, to bring her home.

Catra's first try was in Thaymor, using the stun gun to knock Adora out. The second one was during the Battle of Bright Moon, when Adora was bound by the electrical ropes. The third attempt was in the Northern Reach. What did they all have in common? A group of princesses and an archer standing in the way. After Adora had informed her regarding Shadow Weaver's whereabouts,

she had made it her goal to get rid of She-Ra. And she succeeded. Without She-Ra, the Rebellion wouldn't have much of a chance. At least she no longer had to deal with Miss Perfect Hero.

Catra approached Hordak, who was now sitting by the wrecked portal. "Our troops are just sitting around. What are we waiting for? We need to talk about plans-"

"Plans?" Hordak interrupted, chuckling bitterly. "Your last plan was to set off the portal machine before it was ready."

Catra crossed her arms. "It worked out for us, didn't it? The Rebellion's a mess. Their hero is gone. Now's our chance to gain the upper hand."

Hordak rose to his height and stepped forward. "You didn't even prevent the Princesses from infiltrating the Fright Zone."

Fury bloomed within Catra's heart. She got rid of She-Ra, and this was the thanks she got? The fearsome leader of the Horde should be happy. She-Ra served as a hindrance. Entrapta didn't want to activate the portal. As a result, Catra banished her to Beast Island. Why couldn't Hordak at least appreciate the magicat's efforts? She deserved the credit.

"If you're so desperate for a task, redouble the defenses and make sure that no Princess can set foot in the Fright Zone ever again!" Hordak continued. "Fortunately for you, my signal to Horde Prime went through. Now... get out!"

Catra scowled. She left the sanctum, fuming. It was hard to decide who was worse - Shadow Weaver or Hordak. Both of them didn't give her the credit whenever due. Her claws dug into her palms as she dwelled on another plan. She would remove the crystal from Hordak's chest and make him listen to her.

Glimmer entered the Crystal Castle, then shouted Light Hope's name. She proceeded to say words such as "Eternia" and "She-Ra." So far, the hologram didn't appear. Was Light Hope ignoring

her? She rammed her staff against the floor. A disembodied voice called her an intruder. Red light penetrated the room as robotic spiders approached her. She fought them until they stopped coming. The lighting in the room switched back to normal. She waited for Light Hope to respond. For a solid five minutes, an eerie silence hung in the air.

Muttering in frustration, Glimmer made her way to the exit. She would exhaust her magic supply if she kept fighting the robotic spiders. There had to be another way to get Light Hope's attention. Then, she had an idea. She could get Swift Wind to contact Adora. The alicorn was waiting outside when she found him.

"Swift Wind, try to contact Adora," Glimmer suggested.

Swift Wind's horn glowed as he attempted to sense Adora. Several minutes dragged on. He said, "I can't track her down."

Of course the alicorn was unable to sense Adora. He probably wasn't sentient in the false reality. Glimmer hopped onto Swift Wind's back, and he took to the skies. All she could think about was finding her friend. Would she ever see the warrior again?

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> There's going to be some Bow x Perfuma moments in the story. As for the portal world, I've been considering making it go back and forth in time, since it's a false reality, and as stated in the previous chapter, time works differently in there.
>
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See the end of the chapter for more notes

Night surrounded the land. A few times during dinner, Angella had attempted to start a conversation with Glimmer, only to not receive a single response. Glimmer had skipped dessert and gone straight to her room. Once she was on her floating bed, she opened her journal and began writing. She wished that it was all a dream. If it was, she would wake up and go into Adora's bedroom to say "good morning." Usually, the blonde would have been either training or just goofing off. But her friend wasn't here. Her heart ached at the reminder. She released a yawn as she closed the journal and rested her head on the pillow.

Eventually, sleep took hold. An hour after Glimmer drifted to dreamland, she began tossing and turning. Her heartbeat accelerated. The images that haunted her recent dreams were causing her to mumble in her sleep. The scenery was familiar, yet something was different about it...

...

"Catra, please, don't!"

A large pile of rubble had blocked Glimmer and her friends before they could save Adora. Catra smirked at Adora as she pulled the

lever. The portal buzzed and hummed.

That was when the area dissolved to blackness. The only object to emit light was the portal. Adora stood in front of the portal, her ponytail swaying in the wind. A distinct silhouette with messy hair, large ears, and a tail grabbed Adora from behind and drew the warrior into the portal. The scenery flashed, and Glimmer saw herself in a blank space, with no one around... except for Catra. Her enemy wore an evil grin. The magicat breathed out a sinister chuckle.

"You'll never see your precious Adora again!" Catra spat.

"Catra, you're the worst!" Glimmer retorted as she charged at Catra.

Catra vanished before Glimmer could touch her. The princess breathed heavily, searching the area for any signs of the magicat. Glimmer unleashed a flurry of swear words as she stormed forward. Then, the magicat reappeared. Catra was wearing the same smirk she had before when she pulled the lever.

Catra's tail swished back and forth. "Get used to it."

"Used to what?" Glimmer demanded.

"Adora. Is. Gone. FOREVER!" A cackle escaped Catra's mouth.

...

Glimmer's eyes flung open, and she sat up in bed, panting. She could feel the sweat pouring down her forehead, drenching her hairline and eyebrows. Fragments of the nightmare arose in her mind. It might be a dream, but the emotions were real. She wiped her forehead and reclined on her back, taking deep breaths. How often would the nightmares deprive her of sleep? Weeks? Months? Her entire life? The princess waited for sleep to return, yet she couldn't relax. Couldn't stop thinking about the dream. She buried her face into the pillow, sobbing. By the time it was an hour or so past midnight, she fell asleep.

Morning came. As Queen Angella prepared for the meeting, several guards spoke to her regarding the Horde's recent activities. Glimmer had called the Princess Alliance to the meeting. She also summoned Huntara. Her plan was to find Mara's ship in the Crimson Waste. There were reports that the Horde was planning to steal the ship. One of the princesses would have to join Glimmer and Bow on such a mission. Frosta, Mermista, and Perfuma were in the middle of a conversation.

"There were some Horde spies lurking in Salineas," Mermista said.

Glimmer turned her attention to Mermista. "Horde spies?"

"Yep. I chased them out of my kingdom as soon as I found out."

"Anyways, Bow and I are going to the Crimson Waste to retrieve Mara's ship. Once we find the ship, he'll repair it, and we'll have a spaceship. Which one of you will be joining us?"

Bow rose his hand. "Glimmer, the Crimson Waste is a desert with many plants."

Perfuma smiled. "I'll join in. After all, I can control every kind of plant."

Glimmer nodded. Every mission from now on wouldn't feel the same without Adora. The warrior had always accompanied them on adventures. Their last journey together had resulted in their loss. Today, she and Bow would have their first mission without the warrior...

The desert heat enveloped Glimmer's body as she and her companions walked across the sand. Being out here gave her a sense of dread, recalling how horribly things ended because of the previous excursion. She also felt protective of her friends. Who else would the Horde take from the Rebellion, other than Micah and Adora? Perfuma would probably put up a fight, while their

enemies could outsmart Bow and take him captive. She hoped that they wouldn't run into an ambush.

"Does this feel strange to you?" Glimmer asked Bow.

"What do you mean?" Bow replied.

"Going on an adventure without Adora." Glimmer stared at the sand. "Also, last time we were here, Adora was with us."

Bow looked down. "I guess it is a little strange. But we can fight the Horde without She-Ra."

"We could only go so far without her."

Glimmer strode ahead, replaying the nightmares in her mind. Pushing the images aside, she thought about Mara's ship... and the hologram inside it. Mara did say something about a portal. Could it be the one that almost ended the world? Or was it something different? Shadow Weaver once mentioned the rest of the Horde's armies coming through a portal. Snatches of the dialogue between Perfuma and Huntara interrupted Glimmer's train of thought.

"It must be nice to be home. Do you miss it?" Perfuma said.

"I left. Now I'm here. It's not a big deal," Huntara stated. "So... what do you do?"

"I control plants." Perfuma giggled as she turned her attention to a cactus. "Watch." She focused all her energy into making the plant grow, while Huntara stopped walking and observed the princess of nature. "Hm?"

Huntara crossed her arms, looking unimpressed. "Uh-huh."

Perfuma refused to give up on the plant. The cactus expelled green goo all over her. Huntara smirked before catching up to Glimmer. Behind them, the princess of nature was complaining about the slime.

"If we run into trouble, is flower girl gonna be able to handle herself?" Huntara asked.

"You mean Perfuma? She can be fierce in battle," Glimmer said. "Also, I have sparkly magic, a staff..." She conjured her staff from a pocket dimension. "And decent fighting skills."

Huntara paced ahead, then glanced over her shoulder. "If I could recall properly, you didn't escape the horned girl's chokehold. Your other blonde friend would easily put up a fight, even without She-Ra. I think you are much softer than you realize."

Glimmer came to a sudden halt. The huntress was talking to the commander who once fought during the Battle of Bright Moon despite her powers glitching. Huntara wouldn't have made such a statement had the taller woman been there. She moved past Huntara and blocked her. The huntress wore a smug grin.

"Me? Softer than I realize? I once broke free from Shadow Weaver's binding magic and slammed my fist into her face." Glimmer rose her fist and reenacted the knock-out punch. "Also, when my powers were glitching, I didn't let that stop me from battling my enemies in Bright Moon."

Huntara snorted. "Uh-huh... sure." She stepped past Glimmer.

As much as Glimmer wanted to show off her powers, she knew better than to run out of magic. Her group could stumble into danger during their adventure, and she would rather be prepared. Eventually, Bow and Perfuma caught up to her as they strode down the pathway. The princess of nature whined as she tried once again to remove the green goo. Bow pulled out an arrow, lined it through his weapon, and aimed it at Perfuma. The blonde's eyes widened.

"Bow, what are you-" Perfuma began as she held out her hands.

The arrow emitted a gallon of water, dousing Perfuma's entire body as she shrieked. She wrung out her hair, muttering under her breath. The water dripped from her platinum locks.

"I'm trying to expand my arsenal with new tech. What do you think?" Bow said as he showed off his arrow.

Perfuma glared at Bow. "Why would you have an arrow for this? There are easier ways!" She exhaled audibly. "Your intention was kind. Thank you." Then, she dusted herself off and took Bow's hand.

"Wanna talk about it?" Bow asked.

The group began walking again. Glimmer could see the chemistry between Bow and Perfuma as they chatted. The princess of nature ranted about cacti and proceeded to cry into Bow's arms. While Glimmer's allies were busy hugging, she glanced at a large crater where the ship once stood. Did the Horde take the ship? If it was the case, what were they planning to do with it? She led her friends down the small hill, questions lingering in her mind as she approached the crater.

"What took you kids so long?" Huntara asked as she gazed at the crater.

"Let me guess. The Horde stole the ship," Glimmer said.

Huntara kneeled on the ground, scooping up a handful of sand. "This is *my* home turf. Huntara can track *anything* in the Waste." She licked the sand, probably to study the elements she discovered within. "So, it was the Horde."

Bow pointed to a trail. "We could just follow these."

The journey dragged on for thirty minutes. Large birds hovered in the cloudless sky, flying in circles. Bow and Perfuma held a conversation, while Glimmer observed her surroundings. Her gaze landed on Huntara. The ex-Horde soldier was a mix of annoying and helpful. The annoying part came from teasing anyone that was "soft," as though kindness was a sign of weakness. At least Huntara was helpful when it came to tracking things in the Crimson Waste.

"Why does she have to be the one to help us?" Perfuma asked.

"Because she's good at tracking," Bow said as he fiddled with his tracker pad.

"Can't we find someone who is more pleasant?"

Glimmer walked to Bow's side. "Did you find anything?"

"Not yet," Bow said.

For the rest of the trip, Bow and Perfuma continued chatting. From time to time, they would flirt with each other. Glimmer wore a knowing smile. Those two would be cute together.

Huntara seemed to notice something ahead of the group. "I should have known."

Bow frowned. "Should you, though? Because I don't see anything."

Perfuma shrugged. "Oh, well. We tried!"

Huntara smirked at Perfuma. "Don't give up yet, flower girl." She raced to a cliff, overlooking a valley. "The Valley of the Lost. A smuggler's haven and my home."

The group descended the valley. Smugglers and thieves populated the town, either exchanging items or stealing things that didn't belong to them. There were insect fights in some alleys, and Horde soldiers in others. Huntara grabbed several cloaks and handed them to Glimmer, Perfuma, and Bow. As soon as they navigated an empty street, the tall huntress stopped, then emitted a growl. Glimmer examined the scene in front of them. A familiar pair of figures loitered by a third figure. One of them was stocky and had four arms. The taller one was slender and had a pair of horns.

Huntara growled as she stepped forward. Perfuma grabbed her arm, then said, "I think we should avoid confrontation."

"Are you scared, flower girl?" Huntara asked.

Glimmer cleared her throat. "We're here to recover the ship, not seek confrontation. Besides, we could wind up being outnumbered."

Just then, one of the guards said, "They went this way!"

The group hid behind the large crates. Several Horde soldiers searched the streets for a minute before moving on. Had someone spotted them exploring the Valley? It wasn't really a mission without some sort of danger. However, if they couldn't retrieve the ship, how would Glimmer find some answers regarding portals? Would it be possible to grab Mara's ship without letting anyone get captured?

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Catra meets Double Trouble. And the group finds the ship.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra watched as the soldiers gathered the metallic crates. Before finding the ship, she had taken a purple crystal out of Hordak's exoskeleton in order to make him listen. Also, she had discussed Horde Prime's potential arrival. At the time, she was wearing a new outfit and a slicked-back hairstyle. She glanced at her pad, which displayed a list of items the soldiers had found in the ship. A clumsy Scorpia dropped a box filled to the brim with tools. At this point, the magicat wasn't even surprised by the scorpioni's klutziness. She had come to anticipate the taller woman's mishaps before they even happened. However, if Scorpia kept screwing up, they would wind up being stuck here all day.

"Oh, I am so sorry about that," Scorpia apologized as she regathered the materials and made her way out of the large doors. "Okay, sorry, sorry."

Catra rolled her eyes at the apology. Her companion had always been annoying. The constant disregard for personal space, being clumsy, and not getting work done were some of Scorpia's worst traits. There were times when the white-haired woman was useful, though. Most of the time, though, Scorpia was a nuisance. Footsteps sounded several feet behind her, then approached. Her ears twitched.

"That was fast," Catra said as she turned.

"Miss me already?" Scorpia asked.

Catra scowled. "Weren't you here a few seconds ago? You better not be doing a sloppy job. Also, don't drop anything else. I'm sure you still have some work to do."

"Those guys look like they've got it covered," Scorpia said. "I'd rather be in here with you."

Catra narrowed her eyes, then released a growl as she grabbed Scorpia's shoulders and shoved her against the metal crates. She didn't ask Scorpia to slack off. Instead, she expected the taller woman to help out. Maybe it was an imposter pretending to be Scorpia. And if the imposter was a spy for the Rebellion... She gritted her teeth at the thought. If it were the case, the information would reach the Princess Alliance, namely a certain pink-haired princess and *her* archer friend.

"What's going on?" Catra demanded.

"Again, I am so sorry about-" The real Scorpia said upon returning. Her words came to a halt as she gasped at the sight of her doppleganger. "Okay, this is a thing that I'm seeing. Are you also seeing the two of me?"

Catra glowered at the real Scorpia. "Can anyone tell me what's going on?"

"Oh, I have a twin," Scorpia exclaimed as she approached the imposter. "I've always felt an emptiness inside me..."

Catra didn't care for the rambling. The only thing she wanted was an explanation for this! As she waited for her companion to quit talking, she heard Scorpia mention cloning and paperwork. Her eye twitched.

Scorpia wore a weak smile. "Yeah, being quiet now."

"Finally," Catra spat as she glared at the copy. "Who the fuck are you, and what are you trying to pull?"

The imposter smirked, her eyes glowing as she changed her form. The figure shifted in size and shape. The transformation wasn't as shocking as who she specifically transformed into. Now she was a copy of Catra.

Catra yelped in shock as she backed away. Scorpia seemed to be at a loss, too. The shapeshifter wore the same grin as before. What was this person doing in Horde territory? Her tail flicked back and forth as she crossed her arms. If the intruder was indeed a Rebellion spy, this idiot was toast. Letting out a hiss, she handcuffed the imposter.

"Answer my question!" Catra said.

Meanwhile, Huntara led Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma to an individual called Grox, assuming that the merchant could help the group. Grox had alerted the village to the group's presence. Several Horde soldiers began chasing them through an alley. The pink goat-woman and her short companion hindered them. A pair of soldiers blocked off the other end of the road, sneaking up to Perfuma, Bow, and Glimmer from behind. Perfuma spied a small cactus and attempted to use her powers on it. Bow drew an arrow and pointed his weapon at their enemies. Huntara rammed into the Horde Soldiers and knocked them to the ground.

"You can do this..." Perfuma murmured.

Glimmer kept their attackers at bay using her staff. "Perfuma, didn't you say you could control all kinds of plants?"

The cactus emitted a volley of needles at Perfuma, causing her to shriek in pain as she blocked her face. "I can't do this! Cacti are impossible and stubborn! Why did I join you guys in the first place?"

Huntara scanned the area before grabbing Perfuma's arm and leading her into a dark alley. Glimmer slammed her staff into the barrels, causing them to collapse atop the Horde soldiers. She observed her surroundings before following Bow and the others past several buildings. Eventually, they hid behind a large stack of crates. If she hadn't bought them some precious time, they would have been captured instead.

"Perfuma, what happened back there?" Glimmer asked, watching as their enemies patrolled the streets.

Perfuma plucked a couple needles from herself. "I hate cacti!" She shouted. "There, I said it. I love and honor all things except cacti. And I don't like spitting or the Crimson Waste!"

"It's a pleasure to make your acquaintance," the fake Catra said as they greeted the magicat with a quick bow. "The name's Double Trouble, and I'm about to become your friend."

Catra growled. "I'm done with friends." She gripped Double Trouble's shoulders and forced them to sit on a small crate. "Also, I want you to stop being me!"

"Sorry... I plain forgot." The double blinked sideways. "Sometimes, I get so lost in my character."

Catra stepped back. She had seen and heard so many strange things during her time as a Force Captain; illusions in the Crystal Castle, giant infected bugs in the Northern Reach, and the voice of a hologram inside the ship. But none of them creeped her out as much as this mysterious visitor. She regained her composure as soon as she reacted to Double Trouble's eye movement. Double Trouble gave a small twirl before being encased in darkness. Within seconds, the figure stood several inches taller than Catra, sporting a long tail, green skin, and blonde hair.

Scorpia gasped. "I gotta sit down." She proceeded to sit.

Catra, still suspicious, approached the shapeshifter once more. "Is this what you really look like?"

"More or less," Double Trouble said as they sat back down, crossing one leg over the other. "Of course, we all wear costumes. I just happen to wear other people as costumes... For a price."

Catra lowered her brows. Of course she would encounter people in the Crimson Waste who would ask for money. Unless the price

Double Trouble referred to was something other than that. She did like the possibility of having a shapeshifter work for the Horde. Such a person would infiltrate the Rebellion and inform her of their plans.

"So, you're after money?" Catra asked.

Double Trouble chuckled. "Aren't we all looking for something, darling? But if you don't require someone with my gifts, I'll take my business to the other side."

Wow.

What a bold statement. Double Trouble had the gall to sneak in here masquerading as one of Catra's allies, reveal a desire for money or some reward, and then say that they would join the Rebellion if they didn't get paid. They must be incredibly gutsy today. Catra glanced at the handcuffs, then smirked. How would Double Trouble be able to escape after coming here?

"How exactly are you planning on doing that?" Catra asked.

"I have a knack for getting out of tight spots," Double Trouble said, shifting their wrists as they spoke. "I'm skilled in acting and escapism." They stood, then held the cuffs in their left hand, playfully letting it fall.

"What?" Scorpia blurted out.

"And you can change into anyone? Anytime?" Catra said.

"Ugh. Change," Double Trouble replied, curling their fingers with the word. "What I do is so much more than changing." They leapt onto a metal crate. "I prefer transform! My real gift is committing to my roles. Sure, I can physically replicate anyone, but that doesn't mean a thing if you can't be them emotionally."

A female soldier rushed into the room. "There were rebels in the valley. They fled before we could catch them." After she finished speaking, she left the room.

Catra wore an evil grin. "Double Trouble, do you know what this means? Let's do a trial run."

After the group left the village, they discovered a large crevice, where Mara's ship happened to be. Glimmer spied the wooden scaffoldings and the Horde soldiers patrolling the area. If it weren't for Bow hacking into the Horde's tracking system, they wouldn't have found the ship. She couldn't wait to retrieve the vessel and call it a day, as exciting as the adventure had been. If only a certain nature princess could control cacti... Speaking of whom, the blonde sat upon a boulder, seemingly depressed.

"Did you come up with a plan?" Bow asked.

Glimmer turned her attention to the glum optimist. "Perfuma, the plan depends on you."

"We'll have to think of a different plan," Perfuma said. "I'm useless in the desert."

"Perfuma, you're one of our strongest friends," Bow replied. "You rescued me and Glimmer from the Fright Zone."

"We're not in the Fright Zone. As I pointed out, I'm just a useless flower girl!"

Huntara approached Perfuma, then placed a hand onto the blonde's shoulder. "No, you're not. I've been wrong about a lot. I was wrong to leave my home, and I was wrong about Grox. I'm hoping that I'm
wrong about you, because we need your help."

"You want my help?" Perfuma asked as she made eye contact.

"Yes," Huntara said.

Perfuma accepted Huntara's hand, then rose. With everyone's worries being pushed aside, they braced themselves for the coming battle. Glimmer led her friends into the crevice, navigating

the scaffoldings. The huntress and the nature princess made their way to the base of the crevice. Huntara knocked out the guards. Once the coast was clear, Perfuma raced from her hiding spot to the ship.

A soldier charged at Glimmer, letting out a roar as he pointed the stun baton at her. She dodged the baton, then rammed her staff into his helmet, forcing him to fall. A massive laser slammed into the rocky wall behind her. She observed the cannon. Just as it prepared to shoot another laser, she teleported out of the way. An arrow struck the barrel, disabling the cannon. She continued the assault as more guards ran for her.

"Hey," a familiar voice called over, garnering Glimmer's attention. "Careful with the goods!"

Glimmer clenched her teeth as she gave Catra an intense glare. The magicat had made Adora's life a living hell ever since the warrior left the Horde. Because of her, Adora was gone. Her entire body shook with rage. Catra was the one who pulled the lever and locked Adora in the portal. Fragments of her recurring nightmares surfaced.

"Are you happy now that Adora's gone?" Glimmer shouted. "You are so fucking despicable!" She teleported to Catra's side and swung a fist toward the magicat's jaw.

Before Glimmer's fist reached Catra's jaw, the magicat evaded the attack. The furious princess chased her while trying to land a hit. Catra snickered at Glimmer's attempts before jumping to a platform above the princess. Meanwhile, large roots emerged from the ground, raising Mara's ship into the air. The fighting continued, and soon, the troops retreated. The only foe left was Catra. As she considered teleporting behind Catra and kicking the magicat's spine, large boulders began falling. What should she do? Continue pursuing her enemy, or try to destroy the massive rocks?

"As much as I enjoy the fight, I'm getting bored. See you later," Catra said.

"We're not done yet!" Glimmer retorted as she watched Catra take off.

"We have a problem!" Huntara shouted.

Glimmer whirled around. Sure enough, the boulders were piling atop the ship. If she went after Catra, she would be leaving her friends in danger. She didn't want to lose anyone else. With a sense of determination swelling in her heart, she teleported to the ship. Then, she teleported the rocks off the vessel. A magenta glow enveloped her body as she unleashed kinetic blasts at the debris. Mara's ship moved upward at a much quicker pace than before. The crevice crumbled, bringing on an avalanche. Glimmer placed her hands onto the ship. Sparkles enveloped both her body and the huge vessel as she teleported to the solid ground of the desert.

Glimmer teleported her allies out of the crevice. Once they were standing by the ship, her eyes searched the area for any signs of Catra. The magicat wasn't here. Catra must have returned to the Horde at one point. The mission was a success. Perhaps Mara's hologram would have answers regarding portals. First, Bow would have to fix the ship.

"We did it!" Perfuma said.

Huntara pulled Perfuma into a side-hug. "I'm sorry I doubted you."

"It's alright." Perfuma smiled as she pulled away. "We were all on a journey of personal growth today. I was so wrong to insult your home. It turns out... cacti have flowers, too." She offered a cactus-like crown to the huntress.

Huntara placed the crown upon her head. Then she said, "I need to stay, and take the Waste back for my rebellion and for my people. I won't abandon my home again."

Perfuma rested her hands on Huntara's muscly arm. "I've grown fond of this desert rose."

Huntara lifted Perfuma up. "Let anyone hear you calling me that, and I'll throw you into an exploding cactus!" Her facial expression changed as she began laughing.

The others joined in the laughter. Missions and humor aside, Glimmer couldn't wait to learn more about portals. She had a feeling that she was one step closer to her goal. In the meantime, the Rebellion would have to defend Etheria from the Horde. Still, she would like to bring She-Ra back before it was too late.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> We see Adora and the portal world again. In this chapter, the portal goes back in time. "Flutterina" shows up, and Catra kidnaps a village to get Glimmer's attention.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The bed-ridden Catra grunted in her sleep as she clutched the blanket, her claws digging into the fabric. She attempted to combat the visions that recently haunted her mind after the Rebellion lost She-Ra. The images gave way to nightmares, and she could feel her heart racing. She tossed and turned, cursing under her breath. The magicat was wrong to assume that she wouldn't have any nightmares after the portal almost destroyed the world.

...

"This time, I am going to win!" Catra declared, tensing her shoulders. "We are opening the portal! Now!" She stepped forward.

"No, I won't!" Entrapta retorted. "I need to tell Hordak. He'll understand!" Without another word, she turned to leave.

Catra rammed the stun baton into Entrapta's spine. Thousands of volts enveloped the traitorous woman's body, causing her to wail in pain. Entrapta fell forward, unconscious. Now the magicat saw nothing but red. She spied a shadow looming over Entrapta's body. It didn't take long for her to guess the figure's identity. There was no fear, remorse, or anger in Entrapta's stare. Just emptiness.

"What did you do to me?" Entrapta asked.

Now Catra saw herself all alone, except for the portal in front of her. Due to a strange feeling of being watched, she scanned the

area. As she suspected, there was someone around. A stocky, pink-haired girl glowered at her. She vaguely recalled Double Trouble mentioning Glimmer's reaction to the fake Catra.

"You made your choice. Now live with it!"

It was a familiar line Catra had once heard by Adora. Yet instead of Adora saying those words, it was Glimmer speaking. Unbridled fury darkened the girl's violet eyes. A magical beam slammed into Catra's chest, sending her flying ten feet away.

"Why did you get rid of Adora?" Glimmer shouted before unleashing another kinetic blast in Catra's direction.

"Like she even mattered to me," Catra said.

Glimmer charged at Catra and shoved her into the portal."This is how I deal with bad guys!"

"AAAAhhhhhhhh!"
...

Catra sat up, trembling as she struggled to control her breathing. She hadn't seen Glimmer appear in her recent dreams before. Surveying the area, she released a sigh of relief. The magicat was safe in her room, and she wasn't in any danger of being murdered by angry princesses. She knew she could defend herself, but if she were to face the Princess Alliance on her own, she wouldn't stand much of a chance. Inhaling through her nose, she rested her head on the pillow. An exhale left her lips as she attempted to relax.

beep-beep

"Ahhh!" Catra sat up again. This time, she sat on one knee, glaring at the bot. Entrapta wasn't here to control Emily, which meant the responsibility was now on Scorpia's shoulders. The scorpioni must have given Emily free rein to barge into her room. Her ears flattened against her head. "Fuck you, Emily..." She bent her fingers and swung her hand at the bot. "Get away from me!"

The robot let out an unhappy whir, scrambling amongst its legs before making its way out of Catra's room. Once Emily was gone, Catra groaned before reclining on her bed. Later, she would tell Scorpia to make Emily leave her alone. Even after She-Ra stayed in the portal, the Rebellion still bothered her. So did the Princess Alliance. Yesterday, after Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma stole the ship, she considered having revenge on her enemies. At first, the Horde might have to be subtle. She thought of Double Trouble for a moment. Despite not knowing them well, she had a feeling the shapeshifter would be useful.

So far, the portal world was the strangest place to be in. On several occasions, this world had gone backwards in time. And that was what happened. In this time period, Mara was She-Ra. Adora had to keep a low profile, as she wasn't She-Ra back in the day. The kingdoms looked the same, but with some differences. Currently in Alwyn, she watched Mara enter a house. The town was more populated than she remembered it to be.

A young woman approached Adora. "Hello. I'm Serenia." Her white hair swayed in the wind.

Adora had heard Serenia's name before. George and Lance mentioned Serenia when discussing constellations. Was the constellation named after her? Or was she named after it? The woman in question gave her a quizzical stare. She realized that she hadn't responded to Serenia's introduction.

"Sorry. I was deep in thought. I'm Adora," Adora said.

"The name sounds familiar. Razz has called Mara 'Adora' sometimes. Do you know Razz?" Serenia replied.

"Yes. Also, I'm from the future."

Serenia arched her brow. "The future? So, you're a time traveler?"

"Yeah. Someone recently told me that I wasn't born on Etheria."

The truth was that the portal world had a tendency to go back and forth in time. As a result, Adora could run into people who had been gone for centuries. Would she ever find answers regarding her origins? Ever since Light Hope revealed to her that she came through a portal, she had embarked on a search for answers. But Catra had gotten in the way by activating the portal. She shook her head, replaying her captivity, the collapsing reality, and her sacrifice over and over in her mind.

"Let me get this straight. You're a First One who came from the future," Serenia said. "Did you use a portal?"

"Sort of. An old friend of mine wanted to use it for the wrong reasons," Adora replied.

I'd rather see the whole world end than let you win!

The magicat's words echoed in Adora's mind. Even though the world didn't end, Catra's words still sent a chill down her spine.

"What were their reasons? Did they want to mess up time?" Serenia asked.

"She tried, but I stopped the portal from erasing everything," Adora said. "I don't know how long I'll stay in this time period."

During a meeting in Bright Moon Castle, a child named Flutterina entered the meeting room. She told Glimmer that the Horde captured Bow and the villagers in Elberon. The ambush had happened after Glimmer left a party thrown by Elberon's mayor. Glimmer couldn't help but wonder if Catra was behind this. Maybe the magicat had a trap waiting for her. It didn't sound too far-fetched, as Catra had tricked Adora a few times in the past. Glimmer couldn't afford to walk blindly into a trap. Not when the lives of an entire village were at stake.

"We need to find the people of Elberon," Glimmer said.

"I know I'm small and not a Rebellion fighter," Flutterina said. "But I want to help. Can I come?"

"You can help. Still, you have to be careful. The Horde can be dangerous."

"They took a bunch of my friends, and I wanna save them."

"We will find them." Glimmer turned her attention to the princesses. "Which one of you will join us?"

Mermista crossed her arms. "Uhh, does it involve a sewer system?"

"I don't know if it has a sewer," Glimmer said. "We should come up with a good plan, though. Bow is being held hostage, and we don't have She-Ra." Mentioning the eight-foot tall warrior felt easier than saying her friend's name.

Perfuma smiled. "We can always use plants!"

Frosta encased her fists in ice knuckles. "I can punch the Horde soldiers and their bots!"

Glimmer rose to her height, then rested her palms on the table. "Last time we infiltrated a Horde-infested building without a plan, we lost someone." She would never forget the day her mother broke the news to her regarding Adora. "If we had a plan, we could have saved She-Ra." She strode to the door. "We can't lose anyone else. Once we find a Horde outpost, we can come up with a plan."

Glimmer led her friends into the hallway. A familiar silhouette lingered by one of the doors. *Shadow Weaver?* Glimmer approached the sorceress. Where were Shadow Weaver's guards? The woman better not be planning an escape. Also, the last time Shadow Weaver "helped" the Princess Alliance, *she* drained the princess. And this witch had teleported the princesses to the wrong place in the Fright Zone.

"I see you're on another mission," Shadow Weaver said as she observed the group. "Did something happen to the archer?"

"Forget it, Shadow Weaver," Glimmer replied. "You were no help when you teleported us to the Fright Zone."

"This is the thanks I get? Princess, I can help you become more powerful, if you give me a chance."

Glimmer scowled. "You were draining me the whole time. And you're staying here as a prisoner."

"How can you bring back Adora and take down the Horde if you don't allow yourself to become stronger?"

Glimmer had no intention to give in to mind games. Instead, she said, "Guards!"

Glimmer gave Shadow Weaver her best glare as she watched the guards escort the sorceress to the spare room.

The Princess Alliance discovered a Horde outpost several miles away from Elberon. Hiding in the bushes, Glimmer and her allies scrutinized the outpost. Each entrance was guarded by a soldier. Cameras scanned the vicinity, searching for intruders. She led her friends closer to the base, making sure to remain out of sight. Once they were close enough, she turned to her friends.

"Frosta and Mermista, navigate the entrance on the left. Perfuma and Flutterina, come with me," Glimmer said.

"I hope I don't have to swim in sewer water," Mermista said. "It's gross."

"What if you just summon the water, and I'll turn the water into ice shards?" Frosta suggested.

"We could do that."

Flutterina stroked her chin. "I think I have an idea..."

"Your idea better work," Glimmer said. "We don't want to leave anyone behind while rescuing Bow and the villagers."

Mermista and Frosta made their way to the left entrance. Three minutes later, Flutterina walked past a pair of guards playing tic-tac-toe, while her companions were lurking nearby, waiting to strike. The two of them were busy chatting about their game. She waited for them to notice her presence. Eventually, she grew impatient and cleared her throat. She clasped her hands behind her back, acting innocent as she watched them turn their heads.

Flutterina shrieked. "Oh no, you caught me. How will I ever get away?"

The two guards exchanged confused glances, then chased the child around a corner. As she had imagined, the plan worked. The first of the two guards approached Flutterina. Glimmer swung her staff at the guard's helmet and connected, knocking him out. His companion pointed a stun baton at the princess, only to be hindered by vines. The vines yanked him to the ground, forcing him to drop his data pad.

"Good job, girls," Glimmer said to Flutterina and Perfuma as she grabbed the data pad and led them through the entrance.

Glimmer looked down at the data pad, scrolling through logs and details. Soon, she came across the outline of the base. Perfuma and Flutterina peered at the image. According to the map, their two friends were exploring one side of the building. So far, not a single Horde soldier had spotted Glimmer, Flutterina, and Perfuma. Perhaps Mermista and Frosta attacked the rest of the guards. There didn't seem to be any more officers in the area. Either they were knocked out cold, or Catra didn't bring enough soldiers. The latter could be a possibility.

"We might as well proceed," Glimmer said.

The trio reached the location they were searching for on the map. Yet they didn't find the pit. Was the map outdated? There was something off about this place. Glimmer expected an enemy or two to be waiting for her. She held up her staff, bracing herself for a potential ambush.

"Didn't the map say the pit would be here?" Glimmer asked, glancing around.

"It did," Flutterina said.

"Let's keep looking."

A familiar voice cackled from above, alerting the group to *her* presence. They rose their heads. The sight of the magicat angered Glimmer as she tightened her grip on her staff. Her knuckles blanched. She was ready to strike, in case Catra so much as made a single move. The magicat beckoned Scorpia to her side. It was as if Catra was afraid to face them alone. And *she* should be. Catra wouldn't stand a chance against Glimmer's magic and Perfuma's plants.

"Hey, Sparkles. Took you long enough to show up," Catra said.

"Catra, release Bow and Elberon at once!" Glimmer spat.

"I kidnapped that town, and now I have your attention." Catra snickered, her tail swishing to one side. "Of course you would be here to rescue them. Remember when you tried, but failed, to save your *dear* Adora?" Her finger inched closer to the button in her clawed hand.

"You have some nerve, boasting about taking She-Ra from us!" Glimmer teleported to the bridge, her eyes fixated on Catra as she prepared to strike. "By the way, I took Mara's ship from you!"

Catra evaded Glimmer's staff. "And where are your other friends? Are they lost?"

Perfuma summoned the vines. The plants enveloped Scorpia, then yanked the scorpioni off the bridge. Perfuma said, "I guess you weren't expecting this!" She glanced at Flutterina. "Flutterina, can you run to safety? Glimmer and I can handle this."

Catra smirked as she continued dodging Glimmer's attacks. "Like Adora, you're blind to traps. Perfuma's standing on it right now." She pressed the button.

Orange bolts emerged from the ground and enveloped Perfuma. Six bots surrounded her.

"AAAAhhhhhhhh!"

Glimmer was *so* done. If the Princess Alliance lost Perfuma, she would make Catra pay! "Catra! What the fuck have you done to her?"

Catra chuckled. "I got the idea from Shadow Weaver, by the way. The trap was meant for you, Sparkles, but instead, Perfuma's the one being electrocuted. At least Shadow Weaver was good for something."

"Turn it off!" Glimmer demanded. "You know what, Catra? I'm so sick of you always coming after us! I know Shadow Weaver had been an awful guardian to you, but she also mistreated Adora. The difference is that Adora chose to be kind, while you chose to hurt people. Why did you repeat Shadow Weaver's abusive behavior?"

Catra's smug expression fell. For a couple seconds, silence fell between the two women. Glimmer waited for the magicat to retort, to make excuses, and to fight back. She stared at the button, knowing that the magicat wouldn't let her take it. Perfuma's scream drilled into her ears.

Just then, ice shards flew toward Catra and connected, entrapping her in a case of ice over her limbs. Her legs and her free hand were frozen. "What the-"

Glimmer turned her attention to Mermista and Frosta, who were now destroying the bots. Then, she snatched the button out of Catra's unfrozen hand. Where was Bow, though? And where were the villagers? Before she could ask, a familiar pair of individuals came. A group of villagers accompanied Bow and Flutterina. How did they escape? Did they figure a way out?

"I'm turning it off, since you won't," Glimmer said as she pushed the button. She teleported off the bridge and approached her friends.

The electrical bolts vanished, allowing Perfuma to rise. She smoothed her dress before running over to Bow. As she pulled him into an embrace, she said, "I'm so glad you're okay. But how did you get out?"

"I had some help," Bow said, pulling away. "I borrowed an arrow, combined it with a circular disc, and shot it at the barrier."

"Perfuma, are you okay?" Glimmer asked.

Perfuma made eye contact. "Yes. Thanks for disabling the trap. Also, Mermista and Frosta... thanks for protecting me from the bots."

"You're welcome," Mermista said.

Glimmer made her way to the exit. "Let's escort the villagers to Elberon. We need to make sure that they get home safely."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> Through "Flutterina," the Horde tracks the Rebellion's moves. Angella gives some of her power to Glimmer.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat on the pier, observing the surroundings below. The Horde had failed to retake Elberon. One good thing came out of it; using Double Trouble as a spy. Would she continue running into the Princess Alliance? Considering what had happened, she would rather not do so. Instead, she could attack from a safe distance. That way, they wouldn't gang up on her. If She-Ra had been with them... She shook her head in an attempt to halt any incoming thought of Adora. Glimmer's words repeated in her mind.

"Why did you repeat Shadow Weaver's abusive behavior?"

Catra gritted her teeth, then dug her claws into her palms. It wasn't the first time the pink-haired princess left her speechless. The first time was after Glimmer and Bow dragged a tied-up Catra all over the place.

"She didn't run away from the Horde. She ran away from you!"

"Catra! There you are," Scorpia said as she sat next to the magicat. "Are you okay? Don't worry about that Princess Alliance stuff. I'm here, and there's nothing we can't fix..."

Catra looked away, refusing to look at her annoying companion. She swung her left foot back and forth. Glimmer's question kept surfacing. Was it true? Was she more like Shadow Weaver than she thought? She didn't want to consider it. Sure, she was ruthless and headstrong. But she didn't think that she would be anything similar to the woman who raised her. It didn't even cross her mind. Also, when it came to abusive childhoods, she thought she had it worse than Adora.

"If Entrapta was here, maybe we-" Scorpia began.

"Stop it," Catra spat as she glared at the taller woman. She rose to her height. "Stop badgering me. Stop hovering around me. Just back off! I don't need to explain myself to you. We're not friends!" She saw tears forming in Scorpia's eyes, yet she couldn't bring herself to care. As far as she knew, caring about others was a sign of weakness.

Catra stormed toward the door. "Oh, and Scorpia?" She peered over her shoulder. "Keep Emily out of my sight, or I'll sell her for scrap. Understand?"

Several days passed without a single incident. After hearing a report of a Horde tank carrying a weapon through the Whispering Woods, the Princess Alliance decided to investigate. This time, Netossa and Spinnerella accompanied them. Bow hid in one of the treetops, while the princesses hid in the bushes. As the tank approached, Spinnerella unleashed a wind upon the vehicle, levitated it into the air, and flipped it over. Glimmer emerged from the bushes and pointed at the tank.

"Now!" Glimmer shouted.

A lone soldier emerged from the vehicle, glancing around. Then, he screamed and attempted to run off. Netossa unleashed a net, sweeping the soldier away. She smirked at her wife.

"Boom, nets," Netossa said.

Glimmer approached the tank, then turned to face the princesses. "According to reports, the Horde's new weapon is supposed to be powerful. Otherwise, they wouldn't have a reason for infiltrating the Whispering Woods."

Bow stroked his chin. "If I know Entrapta, this thing is gonna be big, unpredictable, and..."

Gliimmer teleported into the tank to investigate, then teleported back out. "Catra must have intended for us to walk into another trap."

Mermista groaned. "It's *so* like her to trick us."

Frosta conjured a pair of ice knuckles. "Can we go find Catra?"

Before Glimmer could reply, several bots advanced. "Let's eliminate the bots first."

After a half hour of battling the bots, the Princess Alliance returned to the camp with injuries. Spinerella was busy bandaging Netossa's arm. The other princesses had winded up with a few scars here and there. A frustrated Glimmer occupied a seat, massaging her temples. How did the Horde figure out the Rebellion's moves? If this kept going, they would lose. How would she lead the Rebellion to victory if they kept running into traps?

"No matter where we go, the Horde always shows up to *ruin* the mission! If only we have She-Ra..." Glimmer's voice trailed off.

"It's okay, Glimmer," Bow said. "We'll figure this out. Hopefully."

"Without She-Ra, we can't."

Bow sighed. "Remember our time at Dryl? And our trip to the Northern Reach? Both times, the corrupted data disk left her in a daze."

A memory of a loopy Adora surfaced. It had been hard to carry the blonde's body all over the place, not to mention keeping a super close eye on her. Glimmer also recalled Catra using a corrupted data disk to make She-Ra go berserk. The difference was that Catra had played a part the second time. She wondered if Bow was trying to make a point. If it was his intention, the point would be meaningless should the Rebellion face the full might of the Horde.

"Why did you mention those two situations?" Glimmer asked.

"In both cases, we fought without She-Ra's help," Bow replied.

"Both of them didn't involve a fucking army of Horde soldiers." Glimmer clenched her fists. "We need to come up with a plan. Something the Horde will not see coming."

Swift Wind peeked into the tent. "I have some information that could help. The transport came from the mountains, on the far side of Bright Moon."

"That could be where they're keeping the weapon," Bow said. "We have to investigate."

Juliet narrowed her eyes. "A smaller team will avoid detection. Get in and out before the Horde even knows you're there."

Glimmer shrugged. "We haven't decided on a plan yet." She made her way out of the tent. Once she was outside, she saw Flutterina waiting by the entrance.

"Are you guys going on a mission? Can I come?" Flutterina asked.

"Not this time. Juliet thinks that a smaller team may avoid detection," Glimmer said.

"Next time, then," Flutterina said as Glimmer walked away. "Rebellion Soldier Flutterina is ready! Have fun..."

That night, "Flutterina" arrived at the hideout. Catra landed in front of the entrance, smirking. If she hadn't known any better, she would have thought it was a Rebellion soldier or spy snooping around. But this was Double Trouble, disguised as a seemingly innocent child. The look of this disguise could have belonged to a princess. It must have been easy for the Princess Alliance to fall for such deception. It was the reason she didn't like the facade.

"I can't get over how ridiculous you look, 'Flutterina,'" Catra said as she circled the shapeshifter and yanked the purple cloak off.

"Right? I said to myself, 'Double Trouble, what sort of character would the princesses trust?' Someone tooth-achingly cute and pink." Double Trouble transformed into their real self. "Then it came to me. Flutterina. A role for the-"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Yeah, great. Whatever. Is there any news?" She stepped into the hideout.

"Your team did a number on the Rebels. They limped back in, so despondent. Such emotion. It's so breathtaking."

Catra paced ahead, nearing a tank. "Your intel was good, but they still got away."

"Espionage is a long game, kitten. The rebels are tired, demoralized." Double Trouble fell against the tank. "You should've seen Glimmer's face when she realized she'd been outsmarted again." They transformed into Glimmer. "No matter where we go, the Horde always shows up to *ruin* the mission! Angry sparkle, swear..." They reverted to their true form.

Frustration rose within Catra's heart. "Any intel on their next move? Or are we done here?"

Double Trouble ran their fingers through their blonde locks. "So serious. Remember, this is supposed to be fun."

Catra lowered her ears. "This is supposed to be war."

"No reason it can't be both."

Catra growled under her breath. Double Trouble should be taking this seriously, not focus so much on playing around. If it was a game, she would say so. But it wasn't. The Horde's goal was to take down the Rebellion. Her left ear twitched as she glowered into Double Trouble's eyes.

Double Trouble frowned. "All business... no fun. Arrow boy plans to find the weapon. Also... Who are Adora and She-Ra?"

"Bow isn't going to find anything. They'll all see the weapon when the time comes." Catra crossed her arms. "By the way, I don't want to talk about Adora and She-Ra." She stormed to the exit. "Their beloved warrior doesn't matter to me!"

Glimmer strode into Adora's old room, then sat on the bed. She found herself staring at the Sword of Protection. As She-Ra, her friend would have slowed down the Horde's advances. In contrast to the warrior, she could only do so much as a commander. Maybe if she accepted Shadow Weaver's offer to make her stronger... No, it wouldn't be wise to accept the offer. She wanted nothing to do with the woman who abused Adora and played mind games. Yet the witch's words tempted her. Perhaps she could ask her mother if she could have more of the Moonstone's power first. Besides, the queen wasn't as much of a fighter as the princess had been.

The door creaked open, revealing Angella. "Can we talk? I know how much losing Adora has affected you. I miss her, too."

"Of course we can talk," Glimmer said.

Angella stepped forward, then approached Adora's old bed and sat. "I wanted to stop Adora from taking the sword. But she insisted on sacrificing herself."

"I'm not ready to discuss Adora's sacrifice yet." Tears threatened to spill from Glimmer's eyes as she spoke. "Anyways, you have half of the Moonstone's power, right?"

"Yes. Why do you ask?"

"Can I have more of its magic? Besides, you don't use it very often."

Angella nodded. "You're right. Even if we share the Moonstone's magic equally, I barely used it. You're more of a fighter, just like

your father. I will lend you more of that magic. It'll make me less powerful, though. If you gaining more strength will help the Rebellion, then I don't see a reason why I can't give you as much magic as I could spare."

Glimmer and Angella stood under the Moonstone. She gazed at the pastel pinks and purples of the gleaming stone. Maybe the extra magic could help Glimmer lead the Rebellion to victory. If it meant not having to recharge every time she finished a mission, so be it. Still, she wanted to save Adora. When it came to portals, Entrapta was out of the question. As for Light Hope, the hologram had been silent so far. Would there be another option?

Angella wore a fond smile. "You are so strong and brave. If your father was here, he would have been proud of you." She rose her hands, her palms facing the Moonstone.

The stone began glowing, its light enveloping the queen and the princess. Glimmer could feel the power coursing through her veins. Several minutes passed, and as soon as she saw Angella grimace, she furrowed her brows.

"I don't want to take too much from you," Glimmer said.

"I'll be fine," Angella said in a pained voice.

"You can't spare any more. Besides..." Glimmer summoned a small sphere of magic. "I'll test my powers."

Glimmer teleported to Plumeria. She saw that Bow and Perfuma were about to kiss. Her arrival had just startled them. She said, "I'll teleport somewhere else. Bye!" Then, she went to a throne room in Salineas Castle. Once again, she had accidentally interrupted a romantic moment; Mermista and Sea Hawk making out. She returned to the Moonstone, where Angella waited.

"How did it go?" Angella asked.

"I teleported to Plumeria, then to Salineas," Glimmer said. "It may not be limitless, but it's more than what I had before."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When morning came, Glimmer awakened with a start. Scenes from a nightmare surfaced. It was different from her recurring dreams. In the nightmare, she had rescued Adora from the portal, only to lose her again. After that, she had watched as the Horde soldiers tortured her friends and killed her mother. Taking in a deep breath, she shoved the disturbing images out of her mind. None of that had happened... yet. She teleported off the bed, changed into her clothes, and stepped into the hallway. As long as she possessed nearly unlimited powers, the dream wouldn't come true... right? It had felt so real, that she was crying and screaming in her sleep.

Without noticing where she was going, Glimmer made her way to the spare room. Shadow Weaver looked up. The princess could see a smile hidden behind the witch's mask. As if the old woman planned to teach her dark magic... She didn't feel the need to learn such magic. What would her friends and her mother think if she did? And if Adora ever found out upon being brought back home, would the blonde feel betrayed?

"I figured you would come around, princess," Shadow Weaver said.

"You knew I was coming?" Glimmer asked.

"I thought you didn't want me to teach you. I can tell that you're determined to help the Rebellion win the war."

Glimmer sighed. "My mother gave me some of her power, so I don't need to learn some of your spells."

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Are you sure? You could be stronger than your parents, if you're willing to learn from me."

Glimmer couldn't deny that Shadow Weaver had a point. Still, she had no desire to go behind her mother's back. And she didn't want to lie to her friends, either. At the same time, she wanted to be a better sorcerer like her father. She was getting tired of the Horde being two steps ahead. If she acquired some spellcasting knowledge from Shadow Weaver, she could use it to assist the Rebellion and gain the upper hand during the war. Also, she would like to figure out Catra's next move before anyone could get hurt.

"Show me how to think like Catra. She's been two steps ahead the whole time," Glimmer said at last. Her words seemed to satisfy Shadow Weaver.

"You don't need to think like her. Are you willing to use your power?" Shadow Weaver replied.

"How, hypothetically, would I do that?"

"Magic, of course. A location spell is a simple, but powerful tool. All it takes is a few ingredients... and the will to see it through."

Despite every reason not to listen to Shadow Weaver, Glimmer fetched the ingredients and a bowl of water. Even though the witch was imprisoned in the spare room, the woman was somehow able to use magic. She returned to the spare room, then handed the items to the prisoner. The sorceress dumped the ingredients into the bowl. Shadow Weaver grabbed her hand and guided her in tracing a rune. The spell revealed Catra's secret hideout.

"A secret outpost. The Horde has been operating out of the Whispering Woods," Glimmer said.

"Well done," Shadow Weaver replied. "This is the perfect time to strike."

Glimmer teleported to the outpost. A purple orb encased her fist as she crept closer. Catra wouldn't be expecting an attack. She unleashed lavender beams at the soldiers and stormed into the

hideout. How many times had she seen Catra after the portal? Every day? Perhaps the magicat became the leader of the Horde at one point. Was it a reward for getting rid of She-Ra? It wouldn't surprise her if Catra confirmed such a question. The moment her eyes landed on Catra, her palms lit up with sparkles. She shot a pastel purple beam at her enemy.

Catra dodged the kinetic blast, her tail swishing back and forth as she made eye contact. "It's you."

"Who else would it be?" Glimmer retorted.

"At this point, it's not even surprising anymore." Catra wore a smug smile. "It's as if you're out for revenge. Get over it. Adora is-
"

"Don't even start!" Glimmer interrupted with a series of kinetic blasts, forcing the magicat to continue evading her magic. "Can you stop rubbing it in my face? It's getting old!"

Catra leapt onto a bridge. "So is your obsession with revenge!"

Glimmer detected a broken metal crate. Inside the crate stood a broken bot. Her magic must have touched it, because it was emitting electrical sparks. As her gaze swept across the bridges, a smirk tugged at her lips. Obviously, the magicat hadn't expected her to be this powerful. No wonder Catra was avoiding her. Tension penetrated the air as they watched each other. For several seconds, neither woman made a move.

"Didn't anyone teach you to put away your toys? Otherwise, someone might come and break them!" Glimmer said.

"You think I don't have more?" Catra replied.

"Most of your bots aren't here. You don't have a lot of backup, either, leaving you defenseless!"

"All that extra power you have? Wow." Catra crouched on all fours. "You must have been practicing!"

"Guess you don't know everything." Glimmer teleported in front of Catra. "I don't have to worry about limited sparkles anymore." A beam sprang from her palms. Once again, Catra jumped away, falling to the ground.

Catra swung her whip at Glimmer's foot. The whip enveloped her ankle, forcing her off the bridge. The magical beam sliced clear across the explosives, then the ceiling. A bright, fiery glow illuminated the room as Glimmer landed onto her back. She gasped as a bridge descended toward her. As she teleported out of the way, she reappeared near Catra and rammed into her. The magicat bit her wrist, forcing her to let go.

"You even taste like glitter!" Catra said as she flung her whip forward.

A magical sphere emerged from Glimmer's hand as the whip grabbed her wrist. She snatched the whip with her free hand, allowing her sparkles to race across the weapon. A cloud of purple exploded against Catra, sending the magicat flying a few feet away. Catra rose from the ground, and Glimmer began following her. Catra approached a switch and peered over her shoulder.

"I bet you'd like to see our upgrade," Catra said as she pounded the button. "We were saving it for a special occassion, but this'll do."

A large bot appeared, then sank its drill into the ground. Metal crates began falling, and the ground shook. For a moment, Glimmer stared at the bot. So, this was the weapon that Catra meant to send out.

"You're gonna bring the whole place down!" Glimmer shouted over the noise.

Catra shook her head. "Don't worry. I'm not planning to stick around." She leapt toward the exit. "It's revving up to send out a pulse strong enough to level half the woods! So, you better choose..."

Glimmer turned her attention to the bot, then to Catra.

"Me, or the bot?" Catra asked as she ran toward the exit.

Glimmer inched forward, ready to strike, when the ground rumbled. A bridge fell upon Catra. She teleported to the magicat. "Looks like I don't have to!" She teleported back to the bot, wrapped her arms around its leg, and went outside.

Hovering in the sky, Glimmer released the leg seconds before it exploded. She teleported out of the way, then reappeared on a rock beneath Netossa's barrier. Netossa, Spinerella, Bow, and Perfuma were surrounded by vicious bots. Perfuma and Bow gave Glimmer a surprised look. If the commander of the Rebellion had delayed any longer, the bots would have shattered the barrier and destroyed her friends in the process.

"Glimmer?" Bow asked.

Glimmer chuckled. "Thought you needed someone to save the day." She eliminated the bots, while her friends watched in shock and awe.

Later on, the group returned to Bright Moon Castle. Angella hosted a meeting in the meeting room. Glimmer couldn't wait to tell everyone in here the story of what she did. Though, she wanted to keep Shadow Weaver's magic lessons a secret, considering how much the queen disliked the old woman. She didn't regret protecting her friends one bit. After all, they needed someone to help them.

"You should've seen me out there. I was like..." Glimmer demonstrated her moves to everyone. "Hah, kaboom, poof!"

"Commander Glimmer, it's good to defend others," Angella said. "But, you left the castle without telling me."

"So? I went to the Crimson Waste without informing you one time."

"Someone could have gotten hurt."

Glimmer groaned. "Can't we enjoy this victory?"

Angella sighed. "This isn't over. We need to know why the Horde had been ahead of us during the war."

"At least I can use my powers to my advantage."

Bow crossed his arms. "By using me and the Princess Alliance as a decoy?"

Glimmer shrugged. "I know it was dangerous. It was the only chance I had to take out the rest of the bots before Catra could unleash them. Anyways, to celebrate our victory, I'll raid the kitchen for some cake!"

Frosta gasped. "Ooh. Cake sounds good!"

Mermista rose from her chair. "If it doesn't include ice cream, then I'll say no to cake."

Perfuma frowned. "It sounds like a lot of sugar."

The portal world had gone forward in time. So far, Adora had seen a younger Angella, a united colony of magicats, and the Grayskull Squadron. The younger version of Angella reminded her of Glimmer in some ways. Adora's companion, Mara, had been silent as they navigated a mountain. Maybe the woman was thinking about her memories. The wind howled past them, snaking through the trees. Dried leaves crunched under her boots as she wandered along the dirt path. They found a vacant cabin. Darkness surrounded the land as they entered the cabin.

"I've missed out on a lot after I sacrificed myself," Mara said as she approached a window. "I didn't want to die."

"If you didn't have to sacrifice yourself, what would you be doing instead?" Adora asked.

"I would have watched my child grow up. My friends and I would have visited other planets, and we would have grown old together."

"So, after you died, did you think about your friends sometimes?" Adora made her way to the stairs. "I've thought about mine. Wondered if they had moved on without me. If not for the portal, I would have told Glimmer how I felt about her." Her heart ached as she spoke. "We would do anything for each other. Such as that one time in the Fright Zone, I told Shadow Weaver that if I stayed, she should let Glimmer go. When she attempted to wipe my memories, Glimmer knocked her out. Other times, if I'm feeling worried or having nightmares, Glimmer would comfort me."

"You have a crush on her, don't you?" Mara replied.

"Of course," Adora said. "Have you ever been in a relationship?"

Mara nodded. "Serenia and I had been in love. Then, there's my short relationship with Light Hope..."

"What happened between you and Light Hope?"

Silence descended upon the room. Mara looked away, and Adora wondered if the brunette was unprepared for the question. Maybe she shouldn't have asked. She said, "I'm sorry. We could talk about this in the morning."

"You didn't hurt me," Mara said. "No need to apologize. When I figured that she was reprogrammed, I felt upset."

"Why would she be reprogrammed?"

"The First Ones wanted to activate the Heart of Etheria."

"The Heart of Etheria?"

"It was meant to be a destructive weapon," Mara said. "And She-Ra is the key."

Adora wasn't sure how to respond. If it was true, she hoped that the hologram wouldn't try to activate the Heart of Etheria anytime. She ascended the stairs and reclined on a twin bed. As she stared at the ceiling, her eyelids grew heavy. Eventually, she drifted into dreamland. Blurry images surfaced, and as they became clear, she spied a woman with reddish-brown hair and a man with dark blonde hair. The pair stood by two cribs. One was empty, while the other held a newborn. The woman's facial features were similar to Adora's. A stained glass window drew her attention. It had a depiction of Mara and Serenia.

"Wasn't Adora here a few minutes ago?" The woman asked.

The vision faded away, replaced by blackness. Adora's eyes fluttered open. She inhaled deeply as she scanned her surroundings. As she dwelled on the dream, questions arose in her mind. Was the woman her mother? Did she have a twin sibling? Why did they have a depiction of the former She-Ra in their stained glass window? She shifted to her left side. As long as she remained in the portal reality, she wouldn't be able to find her family.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Catra's toxicity causes Scorpia to leave. "Flutterina" sows discord in Glimmer's friendships.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two weeks after having the weapon be eliminated, Catra tried to come up with a strategy that could help the Horde gain the upper hand. However, every plan seemed ineffective. A certain sparkly princess was determined to take down the Horde. She wouldn't let it happen on her watch. After She-Ra had been trapped in the portal, she assumed that she would find it easy to take out the other princesses. So far, there was no success. And Double Trouble wasn't as effective as she had hoped. One day, she organized a meeting. Despite the recent disagreements between her and Scorpia, the taller woman attended the meeting. Before the meeting, Hordak had asked for Entrapta's recordings.

Catra and her fellow officers gathered around a map. "Our forces are wasting their time on useless outposts. We can't afford to lose. We need to come up with something, or Etheria won't be conquered by the time Horde Prime arrives. Double Trouble..."

Double Trouble looked up as they continued filing their nails. "What is it, kitty?"

Scorpia scoffed. "Only I get to call her nicknames. Also, I met her before you did, so..."

Catra glowered at the scorpioni princess. "Don't speak out of turn. You're testing my patience!"

Scorpia shrank back. "Sorry, wildcat."

"Double Trouble, you disguise yourself as Flutterina, right? Why don't you try other roles? Snoop around, find something..." Catra

recalled Angella emerging from the portal with She-Ra's sword. Perhaps she could use it to open a better portal. "Maybe you can find a sword with a golden hilt and a small blue stone. It was a part of the portal. The queen probably took it to Bright Moon Castle."

Scorpia cleared her throat. "Can I speak now? If the portal proves to be as dangerous-"

Catra scraped her claws across the map. "Shut up! If you're not going to add anything useful to the discussion, just leave! While you're at it, go find Entrapta's recordings." She watched as Scorpia left the room.

Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio stared at Catra in shock. Catra whirled around, glaring at them. She said, "What are you looking at?"

Lonnie arched her brows. "You're really temperamental today."

"Because the Princess Alliance kept screwing things up!" Catra's shoulders tensed. "Even without She-Ra, they're being annoying!" She bit back an incoming rant. Relaxing her shoulders, she told herself to redirect the conversation to the important topic. "Starting today, Double Trouble... Go to Bright Moon Castle and put on a variety of disguises while searching for She-Ra's sword. Lonnie, take your companions to several outposts and help the soldiers."

"Ooh, sounds fun," Double Trouble said.

"You better focus on the assignment," Catra replied.

"Still serious as usual."

"Whatever." Catra's ears swiveled. "The meeting is over. I don't want any of you to slack off."

Double Trouble and the trio left the room. Catra ran her fingers through her hair, cursing under her breath. Those people could be so useless sometimes. It had made her wonder if Hordak was the

only one serious about conquering Etheria. He needed to get over Entrapta, though. The geeky princess wouldn't come back from Beast Island anyways. She strode into the hallway, replaying the discussion in her mind. The exhaustion from a lack of sleep weighed down on her, slowing her steps. If it weren't for Sparkles barging into the secret hideout, she wouldn't be having more nightmares than ever. She lifted a hand to her mouth to muffle a yawn. Scorpia's voice drew her attention to an adjacent passageway.

"Hey, where are you-" Scorpia began.

"Who are you talking to?" Catra spat.

"Catra!" Scorpia flinched as she spun around. She was holding a steaming mug. "Oh, hot! Okay. Boy, wow, you can really..." She chuckled nervously. "Heh, sneak up on a gal." She cleared her throat. "Oh... are you okay? Have you been getting enough sleep? Here, I made you some-"

Catra's left eye twitched. "I didn't ask for your opinion. Don't you have a job to do, instead of talking to yourself? Hordak needs Entrapta's recordings!" She massaged her temples. "I'm so close. If I can pull this off, everything will have been worth it. Find me those recordings so I can finish this!"

"Yes. I'll find them. I promise. Did you want any of the tea?" Scorpia wore a smile. Then, her face fell, and she averted her gaze. "You know what, it's not a-"

Catra snatched the mug and chugged the tea. The liquid scalded her throat. Once she was finished, she released an audible exhale. When she saw that Scorpia was still standing here, anger gripped her heart as she tossed the mug to the floor. "What are you still doing here?" She growled as she stormed off.

As time passed, cracks began to form in Glimmer's friendships. At one point, Angella had mentioned the increase in confrontations.

The princess assumed that they were trying to hold her back. Didn't Angella offer her more power? Did her friends expect her to be reckless enough to waste all her magic on the battlefield? She was stronger than before. Why couldn't they see that? After all, she had destroyed the bots a while ago to save her friends. If it weren't for her, they wouldn't be alive. Today, she led the Princess Alliance to an outpost. Since Bow had gotten injured beforehand, he couldn't join them this time.

"Like, do we just rush in?" Mermista asked as she peered past the stone wall.

"Not without Glimmer's orders," Perfuma said.

"I can't wait to punch the soldiers with my ice knuckles," Frosta added in.

Flutterina pulled Glimmer aside, then whispered, "Your friends don't trust you."

Glimmer shook her head. "It's not true. We've been arguing more often."

"Are you sure it's not because they see you as an ineffective commander?"

"We don't have all day for a chit-chat." Glimmer glanced at the princesses. "Besides, we're about to fight the soldiers in this outpost."

Glimmer stepped forward. "Perfuma, unleash the plants. Mermista, if you see a body of water, use it to overwhelm the soldiers. Frosta, you may punch the Horde officers with your ice fists." The princesses followed her orders, battling the officers left and right.

It didn't take long for Glimmer to join the battle. As soon as she teleported between a pair of soldiers, the two of them rushed toward her. She teleported out of the way, then appeared on the ground. Mermista shot water tendrils at the approaching guards,

while Perfuma conjured the vines and restrained their enemies. Frosta fisted her way through the armored squad, throwing punches in all directions. Whenever Glimmer thought she had the chance to attack a Horde soldier, the princesses would interrupt. Why were they like this? She wasn't a weak damsel with limited teleports.

"Let me knock out a few Horde officers!" Glimmer shouted. "My powers are almost unlimited, remember?"

"Almost is the key word," Mermista replied.

Perfuma sent her plants racing after several more soldiers. "We don't want to lose you."

Glimmer's palms emitted kinetic blasts at the Horde soldiers. "I've been teaching myself some spells. And I could lead the Rebellion to victory. What did you see my mother doing most of the time? She's the one holding back!"

Flutterina's scream interrupted the conversation. "Help! They caught me!"

Glimmer gasped as she spied a soldier holding Flutterina. "Let her go, Horde scum!"

"Don't make a move, or the girl... gets it," the soldier said.

Glimmer traced a rune in the air, conjuring a lavender aura that enveloped the soldier. She levitated him into the air, then threw him against a rock. She teleported to him and formed a light blue rune. "It's a truth spell. I'm still getting the hang of it. If it fails, it can be extremely painful."

The soldier flinched. "Okay, okay! Catra called back our bots and our team. I don't know why, I swear! I don't, I really don't!"

Glimmer moved the rune closer to the officer's body. "I think you do."

Perfuma approached. "Glimmer, don't."

The rune vanished. Glimmer turned her attention to the Princess Alliance. "Catra pulled her forces from the Northern Perimeter. We've been wasting our time all day. And this guy is wasting mine!"

"Maybe we should take a break and calm ourselves. The girls may check on their kingdoms soon." Perfuma clasped her hands together. "I've been wanting to check on Bow."

Glimmer shrugged. "Fine by me, I guess. We're in the middle of a war, and we don't have She-Ra. I'm trying my best to protect you guys and the rest of the Rebellion. We lost Adora, and we never know if we're going to lose any more people or not."

Catra stormed back and forth, muttering under her breath. What was taking Scorpia so long? Did the woman get distracted by something or someone? All she wanted to do was give the recordings to Hordak. It was as if life itself wanted to piss her off. Several times today, Horde soldiers had retreated from their outposts. She hadn't heard a single word from Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. Double Trouble had been silent, too. Where was Scorpia now? And most of all, why wasn't she herself on the battlefield, commanding the Horde army? Then, she heard Scorpia come to her. She crossed her arms, scowling.

"You better have something for me," Catra said.

"Entrapta's recordings," Scorpia replied as she glanced at the rectangular chip in her pincers. "She stored them all in Emily."

Catra grabbed the disk. "Are you sure this will work?"

"I guess it should." Scorpia frowned. "The chip got damaged when I extracted it. Hopefully that won't matter. It was so small and, you know, pincers."

Catra balled her left hand into a fist. "You broke the recordings?"

"I didn't mean to."

Catra tossed the recordings aside, leaning forward as her ears flattened against her head. "I asked you to do one thing. One simple thing, and you completely ruined it! But of course you ruined it. Yeah." She pointed an index finger at Scorpia as she spoke. "You're Scorpia. That's what you do." She began pacing back and forth again. "You couldn't handle Emily, and you never shut up. The only thing you did was get in my way! What did I expect?" She gritted her teeth. "I mean, how can you be so useless?"

Scorpia gazed at the floor.

"What?" Catra spat.

Scorpia made eye contact. "You're a bad friend. I used to like you as more than that. But you've been so awful to me." Once she finished speaking, she left the hallway.

As tempted as Catra was to call after Scorpia, she couldn't find it in her heart to reply. She retrieved the broken recordings and stormed to Hordak's lab. It was unbelievable. Scorpia had the nerve to speak to her that way. She didn't care about friendship, as it wasn't her thing. Still, she expected Scorpia to stay in the Horde. All she wanted was personal space. But the scorpioni woman didn't listen. Shoving her thoughts aside, she hid the recordings behind her hip.

"Entrapta must have taken them with her before leaving. There's nothing," Catra said.

Hordak shouted in anger as he shoved the tools off the metal desk. "I gave you an order."

"Get over it." Catra shook her head. "You don't need Entrapta. Also, you don't need a princess telling you what to do! Look what you've done without her. You built an army, an empire! You and me, we don't need anyone. Forget them all. Nothing matters but this mission. Want to prove yourself and your worth? Then do it!

We are going to conquer Etheria. And then, they'll all see." She panted as she concluded her speech.

"Of course..." Hordak faced Catra. "Yes. We will prevail. Give me another day, and I will be ready."

Catra lowered her brows. "Does it mean I can give the command?"

Hordak approached. "It is time."

Catra smirked as she imagined leading the Horde army to victory. She just had to take out the most powerful princess, and then the rest will fall. There was a problem, though; if Sparkles could outsmart her in the last fight, who knew what the princess could do in a future battle? An idea formed in her mind. She could tell Double Trouble to distract the Princess Alliance while the Horde was taking over.

Catra made her way to the meeting room, where it all began. No, she shouldn't think such thoughts. She grabbed a communication pad and pressed a button, waiting for Double Trouble to answer. Hopefully they weren't having too much fun. She occupied a chair as five minutes dragged on. Eventually, "Flutterina" appeared onscreen before transforming into Double Trouble. They sat on a cushion. Behind them were pictures of Adora, Glimmer, and Bow.

"Any intel?" Catra asked.

Double Trouble giggled. "In a nutshell..." They transformed into Bow. "I'm in so much pain. All because I never covered my abs!" Then, they took on Perfuma's appearance. "Oh, no! This is crimping my harmony!" Finally, they impersonated Glimmer. "I may be glittery, but I'm a total badass!"

Catra struggled to contain her laughter. "Double Trouble, I, hah... I'm serious." She threw her head back, cackling. "Stop being silly and give me information. Did you find She-Ra's sword?"

Double Trouble reverted to their true form. "Uh, not yet. While I pretended to be one of the guards, Glimmer said something interesting. She mentioned opening a portal in case things got worse for the Rebellion."

"What would she do if she opened a portal?"

"She plans to retrieve Adora, to bring She-Ra back."

Catra wore an evil grin. "They won't save her. She's stuck in the portal forever. Okay, you disguise yourself as Queen Angella, and ask Glimmer to give you the sword."

"I'll let you know when I take it," Double Trouble replied.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Things start to seem bleak for the Princess Alliance. Catra wonders where Scorpia is, unaware that her former companion has gone to Bright Moon Castle.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For several days, the Horde continued making progress. The Princess Alliance had attempted to retake Dryl, but their mission winded up being a failure. Their suspicions rose even more when Glimmer found out that the Sword of Protection was gone. Angella had denied losing the sword, which made the princess think that there could be a spy lurking in Bright Moon Castle. At one point, she had wondered if Shadow Weaver's spies were responsible. However, as Mermista said, it wasn't always the obvious. The Princess Alliance exchanged their stories, debating the possible identity of the suspect. They even interrogated the guards.

After the Princess Alliance caught "Flutterina" in the dining room, they revealed their true identity: Double Trouble. The shapeshifter admitted to telling Catra about the Rebellion's plans, and confessed to stealing the Sword of Protection so the magicat could open up another portal. The Horde had conquered Salineas while the princesses were bickering. Frosta, Mermista, and Perfuma went home to defend their kingdoms. When morning came, the princesses evacuated a village in Salineas. The sea elves had been devastated over losing their homes. During a meeting in Bright Moon Castle, Scorpia snuck into the palace. It didn't take long for the Princess Alliance to become aware of her presence.

Glimmer and her friends chased Scorpia and a single bot into the courtyard. They glowered at the scorpioni woman, bracing themselves for an attack. Yet Scorpia didn't display any signs of aggression. Were Catra and a squad of Horde soldiers lurking in

the shadows? The bot moved in front of Scorpia, and she rose her pincers in surrender. Glimmer anticipated an ambush as she stared down her foe. She tightened her grip on her staff.

"Why are you here?" Glimmer demanded.

"You ruined Princess Prom," Frosta added in.

"Your friends took over Salineas," Mermista spat.

Perfuma summoned the vines. The plants enveloped Scorpia's body, depriving the woman of any opportunity to strike. "I don't want you lashing out at us. If your bot does anything..."

Scorpia slumped, lowering her gaze. "I'm sorry for being mean. I've done a lot of things in the past. Recently, I started to realize-"

Glimmer arched her brows. It was hard to tell if Scorpia was lying or not. "What did you realize? Did you begin to understand how wrong your actions were? You helped Catra kidnap me and Bow. You didn't seem to mind Catra's horrible choices. And speaking of her, you helped her kidnap Adora. And now..." She emitted an audible sigh. "She's trapped in the portal. I cried to sleep whenever I thought about Adora at night. Will a simple apology erase our losses?"

"I know my apology won't make up for all of that," Scorpia said.

"You're right. As someone once said, actions speak louder than words. And you need to prove that your apology is genuine. Adora meant so much to us. As She-Ra, she helped us a lot. It won't be easy for us to move past your crimes. And we remember the glee in your eyes as you attacked us. You may have to face consequences."

Scorpia nodded.

"But your apology is a start. Now, what were you trying to tell us?" Glimmer continued.

"I wanted to find Entrapta. Catra had sent her to Beast Island before setting off the portal. A few days ago, she mentioned a plan to build a new portal," Scorpia explained. "The last one nearly destroyed the world."

"Since you barged into the castle, you're staying as a prisoner." Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "I don't want you trying to escape."

Bow stepped forward. "Glimmer, maybe Entrapta can build a portal that will help us rescue Adora."

"Bow, are you serious?" Glimmer replied. "Entrapta betrayed us. We have a war to worry about. And no one's going to Beast Island." She teleported Bow to the meeting room. "Why would you want to save a traitor?"

"Entrapta needs us," Bow said.

"Do you even know where Beast Island is?"

"No, but I'll try to track her down."

"How about we talk to Light Hope instead?"

Bow sighed. "She hasn't been responsive the last time you visited the Crystal Castle. I'll get Entrapta."

Glimmer slapped a hand on her forehead. "Are you sure it's a good plan? The Horde's at our doorstep. And you're considering running off on a harebrained rescue mission!"

"You do want to save Entrapta, right? And weren't you determined to bring Adora back?"

"Of course. We'll find a way to retrieve Adora first. She needs us more than Entrapta does. She'll help us win the war, and then we'll rescue Entrapta. We shouldn't risk the whole Alliance for a single princess who joined the Horde."

Bow made his way to the door. "I guess I'll take someone else with me to Beast Island."

"I'm staying here to protect Bright Moon," Glimmer said.

"Catra, last time we opened a portal with this thing, it went haywire," Hordak said, eyeing the sword in Catra's hand. "The only place it should go is the weapon room."

Catra's ears twitched as she left the lab and stormed to the weapon room. Shutting the door behind her, she scrutinized the golden hilt. Her former friend had relied so much on this sword during battles. She had been hoping to see another portal be built, only for Hordak to reject the idea. At least Double Trouble got serious about their role. The princesses had been kept in Bright Moon while the Horde conquered Salineas. Soon, other kingdoms would be under the Horde's control. She hung the sword on the wall, then activated her communication pad. The screen displayed a blinking circle. Where was Double Trouble? Did the Rebellion decide to keep them hostage?

Catra strode into the hallway, muttering to herself. Was the Princess Alliance hoping to extract information out of Double Trouble? What if they caved? Somehow, it didn't sound too far-fetched. Given that the princesses, especially Glimmer, were powerful, the shapeshifter would most likely tell the truth out of fear. As she navigated a corridor, she detected a shadow by the door. She froze in mid-step. Could it be Scorpia? She approached the door, only to find an empty space. Was she imagining things?

Was Catra missing Scorpia more than she thought she would? Or was she losing her sanity? When she was a child, she wanted people to respect her and stick by her side at all times. Shadow Weaver had been unfair by preferring Adora over her. Speaking of the sorceress, Glimmer's words arose in her mind once more. How was she like the woman who raised her? Did that trap remind Sparkles of what Shadow Weaver did to the magicat? She didn't

want to think that she might have anything in common with the sorceress.

Catra made her way to a surveillance area. Then, she began scouring the systems for any trace of Scorpia. Her tail swished to one side as she observed the screens. Either Scorpia fled the Fright Zone, or the woman was called to assist the guards at an outpost. A part of her expected the latter to be true. She caught a figure lurking behind the trees. Was it her?

"Scorpia?" Catra asked as she zoomed the camera closer. The silhouette turned out to be another tree. "Where has she gone?" As she finished speaking, she heard a door open. "Finally!" She rose to her height and checked the door.

Rogelio's arm was wrapped around a limping Kyle as he walked. Lonnie strode alongside them. The trio must have gone through an intense battle, as they sported scars all over their faces. Some scars were bloodier than others. Kyle was the only one wearing armor from head to toe. He wore bandages on his right leg.

"What are you doing?" Catra shouted.

"We just got back," Lonnie said, lowering her brows. "The Eastern Quadrant is secured. No rebel activity."

"Did you see anyone on the field?" Catra crossed her arms. "Anything else?"

"Lots of tired soldiers."

"Get back out there."

"Catra, we already worked a double. We've been going without R and R for days now. We need sleep."

Catra scowled at Lonnie. "Oh, I'm *sorry*, are you tired?" She leapt closer and leaned into Lonnie's personal space. "We're all tired, but we're not going to rest until we have all of Etheria under our

control! Everything is coming together. We're winning. So, get back out there!"

Lonnie narrowed her eyes. "What's the deal?"

"Problem?" Catra spat.

Bow and Perfuma rode Swift Wind to Mara's ship. According to Scorpia, Beast Island contained blood beetles and other hostile creatures. People who were sent there never came back. He couldn't deny that he was feeling nervous about the mission. But, Perfuma's plant magic should be strong enough to restrain dangerous beasts. Bow and Swift Wind strode to the front, scrutinizing the controls.

"There's gotta be a flapping wings button!" Swift Wind said before pressing his muzzle onto a triangular button.

"Swift Wind, let me handle this!" Bow replied as the ship levitated off the ground. The inside of the vessel lit up.

"Hopefully he didn't touch the wrong button," Perfuma said.

Just then, the ship hurried forward at a breakneck speed, startling the trio as they were forced off their feet. Perfuma's scream drilled into Bow's ears. He and Swift Wind fell backward, while Perfuma attempted to grab the chair. His back met a wall. If the ship kept this up, they would be at death's door.

"Never mind, this wasn't it!" Swift Wind shouted.

"This is the total opposite of harmony!" Perfuma shrieked.

Bow's heart raced as he scooted toward the controls. He pounded a button, and the ship began descending. Swift Wind stood behind the chair. Now they were hurtling to their deaths. If it didn't stop...

"Bow, make it stop!" Perfuma pleaded.

"I'm trying!" Bow replied as he punched every button.

"I've never been so terrified in my entire life!"

The ship began moving in circles. Swift Wind sobbed, then said, "Loop de loops! How could you betray me?"

"Administrator detected," a robotic voice said. "What is your query?"

Bow glanced at Perfuma. "Did you find something?"

Perfuma gripped the armrests. "I don't know!"

Bow turned his attention to the board. "Ship, take us down gently!"

"Going in reverse," the robotic voice replied.

"No, no, no! Stop!"

The ship reversed its movement before halting. A few seconds later, the same voice said, "Please state navigational course."

Bow sighed in relief. "Beast Island."

"Affirmative."

Adora sat up in bed, panting. She was still in the cabin. Sweat poured down her face as she performed a breathing exercise and counted backwards. She was safe in here. There was no peril awaiting her. Maybe the portal reality was doing something to her brain. Or, perhaps, the nightmare could be a warning of things to come. Fragments of the dream surfaced; rooms filled with white, green, and black. A towering silhouette. A broken sword. Catra smirking at her. She wondered if things were going south outside the portal world. Slipping out of bed, she approached the window and stared at the distant peaks.

"Adora?" Mara whispered.

"Yes?" Adora replied.

"What's wrong?"

"The world outside the portal reality might be in more danger than ever. I couldn't be there for my friends."

Mara placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. "I'm sure there will be a way."

"What makes you say that?"

"I have a feeling."

"But I'll be stuck in this world forever."

Mara shook her head. "I don't think it will be the case." She left the room.

As comforting as Mara's kindness was, Adora still held doubts regarding the idea of going to her real home. It was difficult to keep track of how long she had been in the portal reality. She rested her palm against the window. Raindrops streaked across the glass panes. If she returned to the true reality, she might find herself in a destroyed Etheria. She pressed her forehead against the glass.

"Maybe you're here to help us."

The familiar words echoed in Adora's mind. Was she the hero that Glimmer and the rest of Etheria deserved, or was she another lost She-Ra? She sunk into a nearby chair, dwelling on memories of her friends. If Mara was right about a possible way out, then maybe the blonde would see Glimmer again. Entrapta would have to create a stable portal in order for that to happen, though. She didn't want to see another instance of reality collapsing in on itself.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> Bow looks for Entrapta. He and Perfuma also find Micah on Beast Island.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The ship landed by the shore. A thick, ominous fog surrounded Beast Island as Bow, Perfuma, and Swift Wind left the ship. A chill penetrated the air as they walked forward. Perfuma grabbed his hand. Was she as scared as he felt? The princess of nature glanced around, frowning. Was she searching for plants? Bow led his allies past a pile of debris. Swift Wind stopped to investigate an abandoned skiff and a broken tracker pad. It didn't take long for the alicorn to uncover Entrapta's mask.

"Entrapta must've been here," Bow said.

"Where do you think she went?" Swift Wind asked. "What is that noise?"

"What noise?"

Swift Wind grunted. "It's gone. You didn't hear it?"

Perfuma scrutinized the ground. "I don't see any plants, but maybe this place has roots." She shuddered visibly. "Beast Island has a lot of negative energy."

Bow paced ahead. "We should get moving while we still have light."

"I was fine going with you to the Crimson Waste during a mission. But, this?" Perfuma pointed to the dark vines and corrupted tech. "Beast Island gives me the creeps."

Bow nodded as he listened to Perfuma's rant. The deeper they went into the island, the more unsettled he felt. Sure, the Whispering Woods had been spooky, but this location was something he would definitely see in a nightmare. As they wandered along the path, Swift Wind began singing. He halted his steps and turned to face the alicorn.

"Which we went to on purpose, so everything's great!" Swift Wind sang as he moved past Bow.

Bow shrugged before moving on. As they continued the journey, he observed his surroundings. Shadows moved between the twisted trees. He couldn't help but wonder if the creatures were watching his group. Compared to the Whispering Woods, it was easier to get lost here. Several creatures hissed, and a strange insect skittered across the ground. Dark vines dangled from the treetops. Eventually, the trio reached a clearing. So far, no trouble. Would they ever find Entrapta, though?

"Maybe everything went quiet for a good reason?" Swift Wind asked.

Bow and Perfuma scrutinized the area, holding their breaths. It was bad enough to not have a map. They could see something much worse. A growl prompted them to whirl around. What he saw froze him to the spot. It was a huge insect with glowing blue eyes.

"No. A bad reason," Bow said.

"Should we run?" Perfuma asked.

"No one move. Maybe it won't see us."

The insect awakened from its slumber. Perfuma summoned her plants and attempted to restrain the beast. Somehow, the plants couldn't hinder it for long. Bow grabbed her hand, leading her away. Swift Wind raced ahead of them. They were here to rescue Entrapta, not to be mauled to death. Of all the missions he had gone on, this one was the most dangerous. Losing one's way and

being chased by vicious creatures was not part of their plan. Also, he couldn't believe that Perfuma's powers were ineffective against the monster. She had been almost unstoppable in battle before. Did Beast Island have an effect on her as it did Swift Wind?

As Bow, Perfuma, and Swift Wind continued running, the princess attempted to use her powers a second time. Then, she emitted a frustrated groan and said, "Come on, plants, help us out!"

The monster loomed over Perfuma. Bow escorted her to a log before it could attack. A purple sphere rammed into its face. It couldn't be Glimmer, as she was too adamant to join him. Shadow Weaver was out of the question, as she was a prisoner at Bright Moon Castle. A hooded man unleashed spells at the insect. Bow and Perfuma watched in awe as their rescuer fought the beast. Several minutes later, the creature ran off.

Bow and Perfuma approached the man. "Thanks for saving us."

"You're safe. For now," the man replied as he removed his hood.

"King Micah? We thought you were dead."

"If the Horde had their way, I would be dead. But I survived." Micah patted Bow's face before pulling away. "Sorry. I have to make sure you were real."

Bow chuckled nervously. "We are real. Anyways, I'm Bow. This is Perfuma and Swift Wind. We're from Bright Moon. Have you ever ran into a short woman with super long pigtails? Her name's Entrapta. And she's obsessed with technology."

"I know her," Micah said. "She prefers tiny rations for some reason."

"Did you see where she went?" Swift Wind asked.

"Why yes." Micah's eyes widened as he grabbed Bow. "Is that horse talking? It has wings!"

"Well, this is definitely Glimmer's dad."

"Your Majesty, could you please let me go?" Bow asked.

Micah released Bow. "Oh, right. Sorry."

Bow hid behind Perfuma. "Do you know where Entrapta is?"

"I saw her go to the center of the island a while ago," Micah said.

After Hordak told Catra to return to the Fright Zone, she had searched the headquarters for Scorpia. She entered the scorpioni woman's room. Photographs and sketches lingered on the wall. No matter how much she claimed to not care about Scorpia, there was a small part of her that appreciated the woman. She retrieved a pile of clothes, a Force Captain badge, and a note from the mattress. Unfolding the paper, she began reading the words. In the letter, Scorpia admitted to leaving the Horde. For the time being, they would no longer be working together. It wasn't the first time that someone left the Horde.

What was it about Catra that made people want to leave her? The clothes, badge, and note slipped from her hands. Was Double Trouble next? She hadn't heard from the shapeshifter ever since they went to Bright Moon. Did the Princess Alliance convince Double Trouble to join the Rebellion? All she wanted was to have someone by her side no matter what. But no! Some people just had to betray her for ridiculous reasons. Did they even care? She strode into the hallway. There was no sense having such thoughts when she had a war to win. At the sound of approaching footsteps, her ears twitched. She looked up.

As it turned out, Lonnie was walking down the hallway. This time, she wore bandages on her left arm. "Catra, don't force me, Kyle, and Rogelio to go back out there. We're injured, and we still didn't get enough sleep."

Catra shoved Lonnie against the wall. "You can't afford to slack off. No one in the Horde should! Not until we win!"

Lonnie's eyes widened. "Catra, why are you against us taking breaks?"

"Were you listening to what I said?" Rigid cords formed in Catra's arms. "Get it through your head. You have a job to do!"

"Back off!" Lonnie broke free from Catra's grip. "You're being tyrannical!"

Catra swiped at Lonnie's cheek, drawing a couple bloody lines. "I don't care if you are desperate for breaks. Now leave, just like everyone else!"

Lonnie stepped back, as if anticipating another strike. Without uttering a single word, she fled the hallway. Catra stormed to her own room and stood in front of her mirror. She was the Force Captain, and the unofficial leader of the Horde. She worked so hard to get to where she currently was. No way she would allow anyone to disrespect her. Would it ever be enough, though? She had never been anyone's favorite person, especially when growing up. Even as Force Captain, she had to outsmart Hordak just to make him listen. After Scorpia abandoned her, things hadn't been any better for the magicat.

Micah had led the group through the forest. As they made their way to the center of Beast Island, they chatted about Bright Moon. From time to time, the exiled king would cast spells on any insect crossing the path. Bow and Perfuma had discussed the man's weird habit of eating bugs. Considering that there wasn't any proper food in this location, it wasn't surprising. Some people would do anything to survive.

"Glimmer and Angella would be so happy to see Micah again," Bow said. "Maybe then, Glimmer will forget about arguing with us." He detected Perfuma staring at her palms. "Are you okay?"

"Not really," Perfuma said. "After escaping the monster earlier, I don't know if I'll help you guys in case we run into grave danger."

She furrowed her brows. "I want all of us to get out of here alive." She rubbed her arms. "How can I protect you if my plants aren't strong enough to hinder the beasts? What if the negative energy is messing with my powers?"

Bow took Perfuma's hands and made eye contact. "Hey, you're stronger than you think. We'll figure this out. You're still the nature princess, I'm the tech master, and... we now have Cool Sorcerer Dad helping us."

"True." Perfuma strode ahead. "I hope we can find Entrapta before it gets dark."

Once they finished their conversation, they proceeded to walk in silence. Bow peered over his shoulder. The hairs on his neck rose, and his senses were on high alert. So far, he hadn't seen anything that could attack him and his group. Yet he couldn't shake off the feeling of being watched. He expelled an audible sigh as he caught up to Perfuma. The blonde glanced at him, then at the vines. Was she still worried about her powers?

"The signal, it's getting stronger," Swift Wind said.

"We're getting closer. Don't let it distract you," Micah said. "Tell me, what is Glimmer like?"

Bow narrowed his eyes. "Stubborn. Real stubborn."

Perfuma wore a smile. "Bow, she just needs some harmony. She hasn't been the same after we lost Adora." She turned her attention to Micah. "Glimmer is courageous, and she doesn't back down from a fight."

Micah cleared his throat. "She's too young to be fighting."

"She's around my age now," Bow said.

"Oh... I've been gone for years, haven't I?" Micah frowned. "How are Angella and Glimmer doing in my absence?"

"Angella misses you, and so does Glimmer. They'll be excited to see-"

Micah held up a hand. "Shh. Did you hear that?"

Bow listened closely. There was some distant chittering, but not the signal that Swift Wind mentioned. "What is it? More creatures?"

"It's the pookas," Micah said.

Bow gasped. "Pookas? That sounds adorable!"

Perfuma shook her head. "Despite how it sounds, I don't think they'll be friendly."

"Let me guess. More scary things?"

"Yes."

Micah kept his gaze on the twisted trees. "Pookas travel in packs, hunting their prey across the island, luring them in and surrounding them until it's too late." He unleashed a magical sphere, exposing the pookas. "Run!"

The group began racing in the opposite direction. Bow and Perfuma shouldn't have came here without Glimmer. Yet the pink-haired princess had refused to join them. He would rather shoot arrows at Horde bots than be pursued by vicious beasts.

"Perfuma, can you try using your powers again?" Bow asked.

Perfuma halted, then spun around. "I'll try." She conjured the vines, launching them at the pookas. Each vine enveloped a pooka. By the time she was done, she clasped her hands together. "I think I trapped them all."

"I hope so."

After yet another hour of exploring the island, they reached a First Ones temple. Along the way, Bow and his allies had found Entrapta. Swift Wind had commented on how terrible the room looked. Entrapta's pigtails twisted a pair of buttons, activating the machine. Multiple screens materialized in the air. The main screen buzzed to life, displaying the First Ones writings.

"Adora's trapped in the portal," Bow said.

"Adora is trapped? That means she chose to stay. I do remember you coming to me for help. Anyways, I've been researching the Heart of Etheria," Entrapta said. "This is what I found." The screen displayed a circle and five runestones. A She-Ra figure appeared in the middle of the circle. "The Heart draws it power from the magic of the princesses. It needs all their runestones engaged for it to work. She-Ra is the key. She will channel and focus the power. However... Since we don't have She-Ra in our world, the Heart cannot be activated."

"We intend to bring Adora back. Can you build a portal that will take us to her?"

"You want her back?" Entrapta stroked her chin. "I'll have to gather the neccessary tools. And how will we leave the island?"

"We're leaving on Mara's spaceship."

Entrapta's eyes widened. "A spaceship? That sounds interesting! I wanna see!"

"You will see it soon," Bow said as he strode to the exit. "Let's go, guys."

Upon discovering that Perfuma and Bow left Bright Moon, she called the princesses to another meeting in the war room. Her friends were exhausted and injured from a recent battle. Things had gone south without She-Ra, just as she thought. The Horde had conquered more territory. Now the Princess Alliance had low morale. Would this cause the current Princess Alliance to split up

for good? None of this would have been the case if She-Ra was still around.

"Ugh. Can't wait to hear more bad news," Mermista said.

"Bow and Perfuma went to get Entrapta from Beast Island," Glimmer said.

"The place where someone stays after going there?" Frosta asked.

"Of course. And I've spoken to Light Hope." Glimmer crossed her arms. "She wants to activate the Heart of Etheria. It'll make us supercharged. Maybe if we activate the Heart, we can crush the Horde."

Shadow Weaver entered the room and stood by Glimmer. "If you bring back the sword, perhaps you can siphon magic from its runestone."

Glimmer gave Shadow Weaver an intense glare. "No one asked for your suggestion. And why aren't your guards with you?"

"So, you don't mind me teaching you magic, yet you're opposed to siphoning the runestone's power?"

Mermista arched a single brow. "This witch is teaching you dark magic?"

Anger gripped Glimmer's heart. "It's not dark magic! She's been helpful so far. Would you rather see me be limited and useless? You need to give Shadow Weaver a chance. She hasn't harmed anyone."

"I thought you said you were teaching yourself."

"I know you don't trust Shadow Weaver, and I know that I should have told the truth earlier," Glimmer replied.

Shadow Weaver shrugged. "Princess Glimmer, how can you turn the tide of the war if you don't borrow the sword's magic?"

"Guards!"

A pair of guards escorted Shadow Weaver out of the room. Glimmer strode to the window, then said, "What do you think about channeling the Heart of Etheria's power?"

"I'll do anything to take back my kingdom," Mermista said. "I say we use the magic."

"The idea of being supercharged sounds cool," Frosta added in.

Glimmer nodded. "We'll tell Perfuma once she gets back."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> Bow goes to Razz for answers regarding the Heart of Etheria. The princesses discuss the Heart.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Later in the day, Bow and Perfuma arrived at Bright Moon Castle. This time, Entrapta accompanied them. When the report of King Micah's presence reached Glimmer's ears, she couldn't believe it. It had to be a dream. Her mother had expressed disbelief, too. Right now, Micah was in the throne room, talking to a tearful Angella. Glimmer was torn between joining the reunion and making sure that Entrapta doesn't screw anything up. Micah looked rougher than she remembered. He sported streaks of gray in his hair. Didn't she see him in the portal world? The memories of the portal world were faint.

"My love, tell me how you survived Beast Island," Angella said.

Micah told Angella the entire story. Then, he said, "I didn't expect to return home to you and Glimmer." He glanced at Glimmer. "I can't believe you're all grown up. Also, your friends told me that you're a courageous fighter."

Glimmer smiled. "They're right." She walked over to her father and hugged him. "We thought you were dead. But you're not. We missed you."

The guards had escorted Entrapta to Scorpia's prison. Like Double Trouble's and Shadow Weaver's prisons, Scorpia's cell was a spare room. Bow had moved the tools from Mara's ship to their prison. Scorpia, who was her usual chatty self, had been silent ever since Entrapta stepped into the room. He couldn't help but wonder if something happened between the two women. Though, Entrapta

seemed less likely to hurt someone. Scorpia wouldn't hesitate to attack a foe. And she wore a gleeful smile whenever she did.

Entrapta's pigtails rummaged through the toolboxes. "The portal should take a few days to complete."

At the mention of building a portal, Scorpia looked up. "Portal?"

"Don't worry. I'll make sure that it won't be unstable," Entrapta said.

"Entrapta, I..." Scorpia's voice trailed off.

"What is it?"

"I should have stood up for you when you refused to set off the other portal. I'm such a bad friend, and I'm sorry."

"If anyone is to blame, I think it's Catra's fault. She's the one who electrocuted me and sent me to Beast Island," Entrapta said. "She's the one who's been a bad friend." Her gaze landed on Emily. "Hey, Emily! How's my favorite bot?" She embraced the bot.

"Emily's the only bot in here," Bow pointed out. "Anyways, let me know when the portal's finished."

Bow strode into the hallway, replaying his recent journey in his mind. The trip to Beast Island stood out to him as the most perilous excursion he had ever gone onto. If it wasn't for Micah saving him and Perfuma from that huge insect, they wouldn't be here right now. The thought of the island still sent shivers up and down his spine. He would probably have nightmares about it tonight. A familiar chime interrupted his thoughts. Glimmer appeared in front of him, peering at the door behind him.

"What's Entrapta doing?" Glimmer asked.

"She's making a portal that will allow us to retrieve Adora," Bow said.

"She shouldn't have permission. Entrapta explodes stuff." Glimmer balled her hands into fists. "We can't trust her. I spoke to Light Hope, and she has suggested that we use the Heart of Etheria to defeat the Horde. The princesses and I will be supercharged. So far, Mermista and Frosta has agreed to use the Heart." She peered past Bow. "Where's Perfuma?"

At the mention of the nature princess, Perfuma walked to Bow's side. She said, "I've been waiting for him. Glimmer, what did you want to discuss?"

"The Heart of Etheria. According to Light Hope, it's a powerful superweapon. Any princess connected to a runestone will be able to tap into the Heart," Glimmer said. "It'll help us win the war."

Earlier, when Bow had been riding Mara's ship with Perfuma, Entrapta, and Micah, the geeky princess had stated that the Heart of Etheria could be destructive. He had watched a video of Mara being overtaken by the power of the Heart. No wonder she seemed to be in pain. He recalled Adora talking about Razz, a woman who lived alone. The woman sometimes called her "Mara." Maybe Razz held answers regarding the previous She-Ra and the Heart of Etheria.

"I don't know if it's a safe option," Bow said.

"Mermista, Frosta, and I will do anything to protect Etheria. Don't you want the planet to be safe from the Horde?" Glimmer spat.

"Of course we do. But it could go wrong."

"At this point..." Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "We can't hold back any longer. I hope Shadow Weaver's magic lessons will pay off."

Bow gasped. "You've been learning magic from Shadow Weaver?"

"Yes. I never enjoyed being the weak princess anyways. Since I'm a commander-"

"Glimmer, listen. Adora wouldn't appreciate you making rash decisions. Especially if such decisions involve the woman who abused her..."

Glimmer scowled. "Shadow Weaver helped me become more powerful. And she hasn't hurt anyone these days. If you care about Etheria, *you* need to trust me and Light Hope."

Perfuma stepped forward. "Glimmer, I know you're stressed. I understand the feeling of wanting to protect others. However-"

"We *are* using the Heart of Etheria." Glimmer's voice rose as she spoke. "End of discussion!" She glared at the duo. "By the way, Adora would agree to using the Heart of Etheria."

Before Bow could respond, Glimmer teleported away. He and Perfuma exchanged glances. The blonde looked as shocked as he felt. For a moment, he wondered if Shadow Weaver had played mind games while mentoring Glimmer. Or maybe the sparkly princess had changed after their loss, being subtle at first. In the past, Glimmer had displayed signs of having a crush on Adora. The pink-haired girl could be quite protective of the warrior sometimes. And when Catra had taken Adora to the Fright Zone, Glimmer had been desperate to rescue her. He couldn't forget how quiet she was after they lost Adora.

"I'll go find Razz. I think she may have some answers," Bow said.

"Okay. In the meantime, I'll check on Plumeria," Perfuma replied.

Bow and Swift Wind visited a small cottage in the Whispering Woods, where Razz must have lived. He slid off the alicorn's back. Adora had told him that she sometimes went to Razz for answers. An old woman shuffled out of the house, carrying a basket. The woman adjusted her glasses, squinting at Bow.

"Mara? Oh, wait, wrong time. Adora?" Razz asked. "She's not here, is she?"

"They're not here. This is Bow," Swift Wind said.

Bow approached Razz. "Can you tell me about Mara and the Heart of Etheria?"

Razz began walking off. "Mara and I were going to make pie today. First, I must find the berries and the sugar."

Bow and Swift Wind shrugged before following the old woman. Adora did say that Razz had a tendency to mix up the past and present. Either Razz was a time traveler, or she was struggling with memory problems. It could be both. As they navigated the woods, Razz said something about "Loo-Kee" hiding in the trees. Bow and Swift Wind climbed over a log as they continued following her. Were they going to Mara's ship?

"She's kind of wacky," Swift Wind pointed out.

"She helped Adora sometimes," Bow replied. "I think she's leading us to the right place."

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah. If not for Razz, Adora wouldn't have found you."

Swift Wind stared at the trees. "Did we just lose Razz?"

Bow scrutinized the area. "Razz?" He called out. Then, he proceeded forward. "Let's keep going."

"Sure. But I doubt we'll find anything," Swift Wind said as they wandered into a clearing.

Bow's gaze landed on a fragmented statue of She-Ra. It was covered in vines and moss, broken down with the passage of time. At one point, it could have been a majestic sight to behold. He stepped closer. Huge gashes on the statue drew his attention. Only a sword could have sliced into the statue. Pushing away the moss, he uncovered a pile of boxes and a single disk. He retrieved the disk and picked up a box.

"Ah, you found it," Razz said as she grabbed the box and placed it into her basket. "Now I'll pick the berries."

Bow and Swift Wind left the clearing, watching Razz gather the berries. He said, "Did this belong to Mara?" He showed the disk to Razz.

"Yes. She left it for Adora. Mara has an important message."

"Adora's not in this world. And Mara has been gone for centuries."

Razz turned to face Bow. "Hmm? No, that doesn't sound right. Mara's helping me make a pie today. She promised, you know." She walked to another bush and collected more berries.

"Why is today the day you make a pie?" Bow asked.

"Today's important," Razz said. "Because..." She scratched her head, looking away.

The woman proceeded to tell Bow the story of the day Mara calmed down a boar-like creature. Then, Razz said, "Mara, your people made the sword, but they did not make She-Ra."

Bow furrowed his brows. "Are you talking about the First Ones?"

"The sword... Mara... She said she would come back. We were going to make the pie."

Bow heard a tinge of sadness in Razz's voice as she spoke. Those two women were probably close friends. A small golden orb floated past him. "Had Mara been here? The berries, sugar, making the pie... it helps you remember, doesn't it?"

"Oh, Mara... you were never supposed to succeed." Razz's voice cracked. "They made a plan for you. Razz could not do anything to help. I am sorry."

"Then help me," Bow said. "Bow, a friend of Adora. I want to get Adora out of the portal world, and I want to know if the Heart of

Etheria is harmful or not."

"There is a great evil at the Heart of Etheria, and it is waking up again." Razz hurried toward the cottage. "It's getting late. I have to put the pie in."

Later on, Bow and Swift Wind followed Razz to Mara's ship. It was dark out. They must have been here for a few hours. Once they were inside the ship, he searched the consoles and found a slot. He inserted the disk into the slot. The First Ones writings glowed, and two holograms appeared. Mara grunted as she approached the console. She tapped the buttons, panting as she rested her hands on the surface. Light Hope seemed angry. As the recording continued, the taller hologram spoke coolly to Mara. Eventually, the recording paused, and Mara reappeared in front of the chair.

"I know you're there," Mara said. "Razz said you would be there." She held up her hand for someone to touch. Maybe Adora was supposed to touch her hand. But the blonde wasn't here.

Mara occupied the chair. "I didn't have much time. I barely made it out..."

The message continued. Mara talked about the Heart of Etheria Project, and why Light Hope shouldn't be trusted. Her description of the Heart as a weapon frightened Bow. He had to warn the Princess Alliance. Despite how bleak things were for the princesses, they shouldn't activate it. Once the recording stopped, he replayed the words in his mind. It sounded concerning. If She-Ra was the key, it meant that Light Hope intended to use Adora to set off the Heart.

"She was brave, my Mara," Razz said as she placed the pie onto the empty chair. "For you, Mara, dearie."

Glimmer summoned the princesses to the meeting room. Her parents had gone to the living room after dinner, still chatting.

This time, Bow was present. He looked as though he had something important to say. If he hoped to give her a reason to not use the Heart of Etheria, he should forget about it. So far, Mermista and Frosta had agreed to use the superweapon. Perfuma hadn't said anything yet.

"Mara warned against using the Heart of Etheria," Bow said.

"This again, Bow?" Glimmer retorted. "Perfuma, share your thoughts regarding the Heart. I want to know if you agree or not."

Perfuma shrugged. "Bow's right."

Glimmer shook her head. "We've lost so much to the Horde."

"It's unstable," Bow said. "Tampering with it could-"

"You heard me. We're running out of options! So I say we get Light Hope to tell us how it works, and take our power back."

Bow frowned. "She'll set the weapon off. Instead of activating it, we have to make sure it doesn't destroy everything!"

Glimmer rammed her fists against the table. "The Horde took over various locations. Alwyn, Thaymor, Salineas..."

Mermista nodded. "I say we use it, no matter how Bow and Perfuma feel about it."

"First, I'll bring back Adora. She'll help us tap into the Heart."

"And how will you bring her back?" Mermista asked.

"Entrapta's building a portal," Glimmer said. "Once she's done, I'll bring Adora home. And we'll have She-Ra again."

Frosta yawned. "Can we continue this in the morning?"

Perfuma made her way to Bow and kissed him, then said, "I'll see you tomorrow." She strode to the door.

Glimmer watched as the princesses left the room. "Bow, you'll thank us later when the war is over. Mara probably didn't use the Heart of Etheria the right way."

Bow crossed his arms. "If you saw her recording, you wouldn't be suggesting that we use the Heart of Etheria. If Mara hadn't sacrificed herself, none of us would be here today."

"I don't see any other alternative."

"But-"

Glimmer lowered her brows. "We're done talking."

Bow opened his mouth, but he didn't speak. He walked out, the door slamming behind him. Glimmer teleported to one of the spare rooms, where Scorpia and Entrapta were being held. She saw Entrapta assembling metallic parts and fiddling with the tools. Entrapta halted her work, removed her mask, and turned her attention to Glimmer. Would the geeky princess run back to the Horde if she had the opportunity? Entrapta was the one who built the faulty portal and created Horde bots.

"Hi," Entrapta said, grinning from ear to ear. "I've been working on the portal, and-"

"Don't mess this up," Glimmer replied. "We don't need reality to collapse in on itself."

"Once I'm done, I'll run a few tests on the portal before it can be activated."

"After that... are you going to return to the Horde?"

"No. I'm not going back." Entrapta shuddered, as though remembering a bad memory. "Catra hurt me. All because I didn't want to set off the first portal."

"Do you promise to be loyal to the Rebellion?" Glimmer asked.

"I promise." Entrapta's words sounded sincere.

"I hope you keep the promise," Glimmer said.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

The sequel will be out soon.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As Entrapta had predicted, the portal took a few days to complete. She ran a couple tests and smoothed out any flaws. This time, the portal didn't need She-Ra's sword in order to function. Glimmer had spoken to Angella and Micah regarding the portal, and they agreed to let her retrieve Adora. Glimmer, Swift Wind, and Bow entered the portal and found themselves in an abandoned world. It caused her to wonder, for a second, if Adora was truly gone. She told herself not to give up. The blonde had to be here somewhere.

Glimmer and Bow mounted Swift Wind. The alicorn took to the skies, searching the world. Swift Wind's horn glowed as he flew in a specific direction. Eventually, they arrived in the mountains and proceeded to explore the area. They followed the dirt path to a cabin. She spied a familiar face in the window. Was it Adora? Within seconds, the front door swung open. Adora stepped out, shutting the door behind her.

"Glimmer? Bow? Swift Wind?" Adora asked.

"We're here to take you home," Glimmer replied.

"Did you come here through a portal?"

Glimmer took Adora's hand, then led her toward Swift Wind. "We did. There's a lot to catch up on."

Adora gasped. "How long was I gone?"

"A few months."

"Tell me everything."

And Glimmer did. The Best Friend Squad rode Swift Wind to the portal as they chatted. From time to time, Adora would say "whoa" as Glimmer shared the stories. At one point, Adora mentioned time travel and her nightmares. If it was a dream, Glimmer would have woken up to discover that Adora was still gone. But this was happening for real. They made their way through the portal, winding up in the spare room. Entrapta had turned part of the room into a makeshift lab. Scorpia's side was untouched. Even though Glimmer warned Adora of the two women's presence beforehand, the warrior still looked surprised.

Glimmer teleported Adora and Bow to the meeting room, where the Princess Alliance had gathered. She watched as Adora and Bow sat down. It felt so unreal, seeing her friend back home. There was one thing the hero needed, though. The Sword of Protection. And Double Trouble had stolen it so Catra could use it for another portal. Without it, Adora wouldn't tap into the Heart of Etheria.

"While you were stuck in the portal, the Rebellion was losing," Glimmer said.

"Okay. And where's my sword?" Adora asked.

"Catra's spy, Double Trouble, stole the sword."

Adora rose to her height. "I'll go to the Fright Zone."

Glimmer made eye contact. "You can't rush in there without backup. I don't want to lose you again. Catra could open up another portal, you could get your mind wiped, or worse..."

"I'll sneak around. I know the layout of the entire place," Adora said.

Bow shook his head. "Adora, Glimmer's right. You can't go alone. A Horde soldier could catch you, no matter how careful you attempt to be."

Mermista sighed. "Adora, I'll go with you. I know the sewer system."

"I'll go, too," Bow said.

Glimmer nodded. "It will be a quick mission. Find the sword and come back to Bright Moon Castle. The other princesses and I will fight the Horde."

As the princesses and Bow left the room, Glimmer walked over to Adora and grabbed her hands. "Adora, before you leave, I want to tell you something. I... I like you, and I see you as more than just a friend. So... please stay alive. When you stayed in the portal, I thought I had lost you forever."

"I'll be fine," Adora said as she embraced Glimmer and kissed her forehead. "I like you, too."

Glimmer watched as Adora stepped through the door, wishing that she would continue holding the warrior in her embrace. But that would prevent Adora from retrieving the Sword of Protection. Also, she planned to tell Light Hope that the Princess Alliance was ready to be supercharged by the Heart of Etheria. She strode into the hallway, searching for Scorpia's room. According to Light Hope, Scorpia was one of the princesses who hadn't accepted her destiny yet.

Once Bow, Mermista, and Adora arrived in the Fright Zone, they noticed a lack of activity in the area. Adora led her friends into the main headquarters. The hairs on her neck stood. It felt too easy. Almost as if their enemies had prepared a trap for them. It was the reason she had taken a sword from Bright Moon Castle's armory. That way, she would fight her way out. The trio snuck past the guards, occasionally hiding behind a large crate or a pillar. An eerie silence hung in the air as they went through multiple doors.

"We should remain alert," Adora said as she drew the sword.

"Yeah," Bow replied.

Mermista groaned. "Will we ever find She-Ra's sword?"

Adora shrugged. "I hope so. Maybe it's in the sanctum?"

A familiar sound of claws scratching the floor prompted Adora to whirl around. Catra smirked, approaching the group. She held the Sword of Protection in her left hand. Her other hand was behind her back. Was the magicat planning to trick the warrior? Adora glowered at her foe. Unbridled fury darkened the magicat's eyes, her tail flicking back and forth.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said. "Looking for something?" She dropped the Sword of Protection at Adora's feet. "When you were trapped in the portal, I thought I eliminated you for good. I was leading the Horde to victory. And you showed up. You must be so special, that you somehow survived the portal."

Adora grabbed the Sword of Protection and tossed the other blade aside. Once again, too easy. "I've had enough of your games, Catra." She pointed her sword toward the ceiling. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Catra rammed a corrupted disk into Adora's sword. "You didn't see this coming, did you? There's more of this First Ones tech than I thought."

The crimson vines snaked across the golden hilt and reached Adora's hand. She let out an agonized scream, while Catra watched in sheer amusement. Mermista summoned water tendrils from the sewers and launched them toward the cat captain. The blonde warrior began lashing out, not caring who she would hit. A dozen soldiers poured into the hallway and charged at the trio. Catra lunged at Bow and knocked him to the floor.

"Why are you so desperate to ruin her life?" Bow asked as he blocked his face with his weapon.

Catra hissed. "Because she's not in the portal. When the cameras caught you three sneaking around, I had to investigate." Her ears flattened against her head. "And my suspicions were correct." She swung a clawed hand at Bow's face and connected.

"Ow!" Bow's hand moved to his cheek.

Mermista unleashed the water at the soldiers, knocking them off their feet. A water tendril slammed into Catra and sent her flying toward the wall, forcing the magicat to drop the corrupted disk. Bow rose from the floor. Adora charged at him, but he was quick to dodge the blows and catch an incoming strike with his bow. He gripped the hilt and struggled to pry it from her hand. Then, he shoved his bow into Adora's chest. She released her vice grip on the sword, slumping over. He caught her before she could fall. Mermista launched the water at the remaining soldiers, emptying the hallway.

Bow shot an arrow at the disk, shattering it upon impact. Catra rose to her height, widening her stance. She let out an angry hiss before advancing. The archer fired a trick arrow that transformed into a net. As the net ensnared Catra, she glared at Bow, growling as she clawed her way out of the net.

Adora's eyes fluttered open. She stood, then grabbed the Sword of Protection and repeated the words she had shouted earlier. As soon as she transformed into She-Ra, lines of glowing veins appeared on her body. The same lines materialized on Mermista's arms. A bright light enveloped the two women. It was unlike the glow the Princess Alliance emitted whenever all of them were together.

"It's the Heart of Etheria," Bow said in a worried tone.

"Let's go to Bright Moon," Mermista replied.

Beams shot through the ceiling. The walls crumbled as Adora struggled to bring down her sword. "Bow... Mermista... you need to run to safety."

"We're not leaving without you," Bow said as he evaded the falling debris.

Mermista snatched Bow's wrist and led him away. Adora's body vibrated as she let out a shaky breath. A scream ripped from her lips. The agony was too much. Was it how Mara felt when trying to stop the Heart of Etheria? The crumbling debris almost hit her as she tried once again to lower the sword.

Glimmer donned herself in full armor. Earlier, she had teleported Scorpia to the Fright Zone and told her to connect with the Black Garnet. She had also spoken to Light Hope before returning to Bright Moon. Outside the castle, an army of Horde soldiers and bots advanced. She rushed into battle, blasting soldiers left and right. Rebellion soldiers charged at the Horde army, attacking their enemies. On the other side of the battlefield, the princesses began glowing. A few Horde bots lurked in the trees, firing a volley of beams in all directions.

Glimmer channeled the newfound power into her blasts, decimating the Horde bots and sending many Horde soldiers flying into the Whispering Woods. Perfuma's vines toppled the tanks, while Frosta punched the remaining bots. Runestone veins appeared on Glimmer's arms as pain flooded her body. Bow was right. The Heart of Etheria was unstable. She should have listened, yet she didn't. The other princesses hollered in agony. Several Horde soldiers proceeded to torture them with their weapons. On the other side of the battlefield, Micah unleashed spell after spell at the army.

Adora, Mermista, and Bow hadn't arrived yet. Were they still in the Fright Zone?

Adora had no desire to be used as a weapon. Each time she brought the sword toward the floor, an invisible force would move the blade upward. *Come on,* she told herself. She wanted to smash the sword, but the energy was hindering her effort. She

grunted as she lowered the blade. A vision of Light Hope surfaced in her mind.

"Initiate planetary move, out of the Dimension of Despondos."

"I'm not a weapon!" Adora shouted as she slammed the blade into the floor. Exhaustion weighed down on her as she reverted to her normal form. She fell to her knees, staring at the broken pieces.

"Adora..." Catra said as she approached the blonde. "Looks like you're no longer She-Ra." She wrapped her fingers around Adora's neck and lifted her off the floor. Then, she swiped at her face, slashing her cheekbone.

Adora's foot collided into Catra's stomach, prompting the magicat to release her. She landed onto her back, and before she could get up, Catra pinned her to the floor. Her mind flashed back to their confrontation in the portal. Half of Catra's body had turned pitch black. The magicat had worn a wide smile, speaking in a distorted voice. The memory faded as soon as it came. Adrenaline coursed through her veins as she blocked her face with both arms. Catra's claws ripped into her arms, drawing bloody lines from her elbows to her wrists.

Adora gripped Catra's wrists as the magicat struggled to touch her. "You've caused enough damage. To me, to the Rebellion, and to Etheria! What did I ever do to deserve this?"

"Since the portal hasn't killed you, I'll finish you off for good!" Catra retorted as she grabbed a shard and slashed Adora clear across the blonde's abdomen.

Adora shoved Catra off, wincing in pain as she forced herself up. Blood flowed freely, staining her jacket and shirt. The magicat lunged forward. She jumped out of the way before Catra could hit her. Dodging the magicat, she watched for an opening. Catra leapt to the hole in the ceiling, then flashed a feral grin.

"Catra, give it up," Adora said as she clutched her abdomen. Blood trickled onto her palm. "Have you lived with your choices?"

"Are you getting tired?" Catra replied as she stared down at Adora.

"Don't start."

"I'm surprised that you would break your sword." Catra snickered. "And where are your friends?"

Adora gritted her teeth. "Catra... I'm so done with your shit. I've given you a few chances to leave the Horde. And you didn't. You chose to hurt me and my friends."

Catra's ears twitched. "Whatever. Someone's coming. I bet it's Horde Prime."

Adora detected a ship hovering in the sky. The vessel emitted a green glow. Catra glanced at the ship, then at her. Didn't the magicat want to finish off the blonde? The green glow began levitating Adora and Catra into the air. What was happening? Did someone on the ship capture them? She recalled her last conversation with Glimmer. They had been separated again, and she was no longer She-Ra. By the time the light disappeared, she found herself in a clean and crisp hall. A towering figure approached Hordak. This must be Horde Prime.

"Little Brother... it has been a long time."

"I have conquered Etheria for you," Hordak said. "I have bent its people to my will."

"Why can I not see your thoughts?" Horde Prime replied.

Adora stood, and so did Catra. She wondered if her friends were searching the Fright Zone for her. Had they also seen the ship? Hordak's pained shout interrupted her train of thought.

"Take him to be reconditioned," Horde Prime said. Then, he glanced at Adora and Catra. "Looks like I have guests."

"Your ship brought us here," Catra pointed out. "Also, you don't want to destroy Etheria. It's some kind of huge superweapon. She-Ra is a part of it. If you wanna learn how to use it, you need me."

The injured princesses had been taken to the infirmary. When Bow and Mermista arrived at Bright Moon Castle, Glimmer noticed that Adora hadn't accompanied them. Dread settled in her stomach. Adora must have broken the sword at one point. They didn't lose her, right?

"Adora's gone. They took her. What do we do?" Bow said.

"We must save her," Glimmer said.

Mermista rolled her eyes. "So much for the Heart of Etheria."

And there it was. Guilt flooded Glimmer's heart. If she hadn't rushed ahead and told Light Hope to activate the superweapon, none of this would have happened. Adora would still be here, safe and sound, instead of being held hostage. Tears pooled in the corners of her eyes. She reminded herself to be strong and not let guilt overwhelm her.

"We need to come up with a plan," Glimmer said.

Hopefully their plan would work. Glimmer strode to Adora's room, swallowing a sob as she sat on the empty bed. She had retrieved Adora from the portal, only for her to be gone again. As she made her way to the window, she glimpsed a few ships hovering in the sky. Was Adora on one of them? She pressed a palm against the glass.

"I'll find you," Glimmer whispered.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading!

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